

Ordered Action Tokens for Visuomotor Policy Learning

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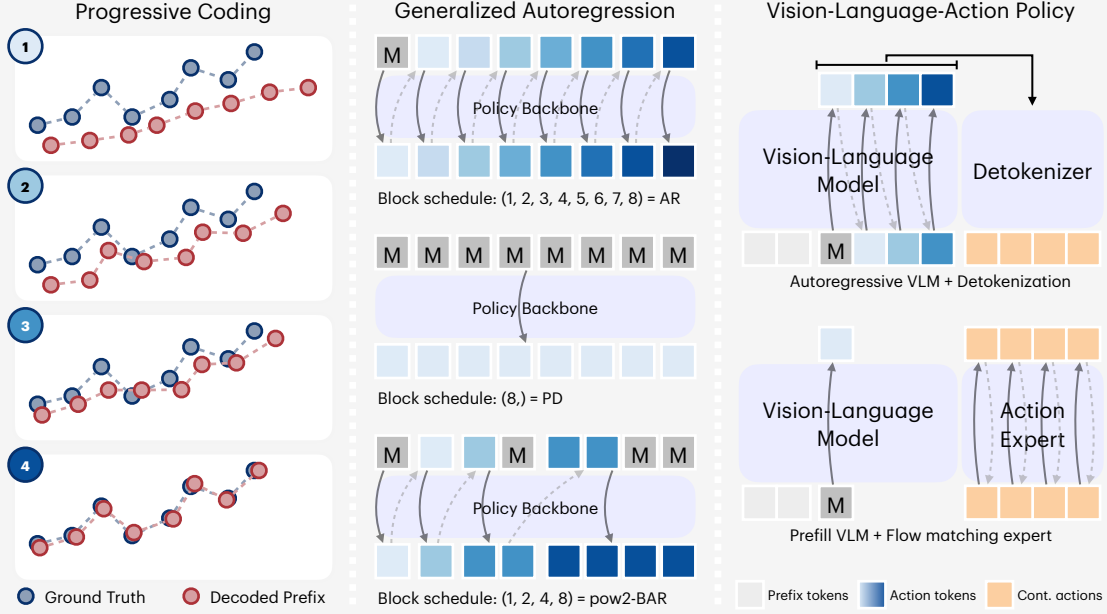


Figure 1: OAT tokens for visuomotor policy learning. **Left:** OAT encodes each action chunk as an ordered token sequence whose prefixes decode to plausible action chunks, with later tokens refining control. **Middle:** In autoregressive policies, OAT tokens can be block-wise generated under schedules spanning token-wise autoregression (**top**), fixed-size blocks, power-of-two grouping (**middle**), and parallel decoding (**bottom**). **Right:** We validate OAT in two prevailing uses of tokens: autoregressive policies that generate tokens decoded into control (**top**), and token co-training policies, where tokens supervise the vision-language model while a flow-matching expert generates actions from the resulting context (**bottom**).

🌐 **Website:** ordered-action-tokenization.github.io

🔗 **Code:** Chaoqi-LIU/oat; Chaoqi-LIU/praxis-vla

Abstract

Action tokenization maps continuous robot action chunks to discrete tokens and has become an important interface for modern visuomotor policies. Existing approaches either rely on analytical discretization methods that produce prohibitively long token sequences or learned latent tokenizers that lack structure, limiting their compatibility with downstream policies. In this work, we identify three desiderata for action tokenization – high compression, total decodability, and a causally ordered token space – and introduce Ordered Action Tokenization (OAT), a learned action tokenizer that satisfies all three. OAT discretizes action chunks into an ordered sequence of tokens using a transformer with registers, finite scalar quantization, and ordering-inducing training mechanisms. By training each token prefix to decode into a valid action chunk,

OAT places coarse control information in early tokens and uses later tokens to refine residual detail, yielding an anytime tradeoff between inference cost and action fidelity. We validate **OAT** in two prevailing uses of action tokens: autoregressive policies that generate tokens for control, and token co-training policies that use token losses to shape the vision-language model context consumed by a flow-based action expert. Across three policy backbones and more than 60 tasks spanning five simulation benchmarks and real-world settings, **OAT** consistently improves policy performance while offering significantly greater flexibility at inference time.

1 Introduction

Action tokens are the interface between continuous robot control and sequence modeling, yet the design of this interface remains under-examined. Experience from language and vision shows that tokenization shapes learning dynamics, model capacity, scalability, and downstream performance (Sennrich et al., 2016; van den Oord et al., 2017; Mentzer et al., 2024; Bachmann et al., 2025). Same for robot control, action tokenization is not merely offline compression: tokens determine the output length, the validity of arbitrary policy samples, and how control-relevant information is organized for prediction or supervision. Therefore, tokens must be designed with the policy interface in mind, so that they are easy for policies to predict or learn from. This raises a basic question: what properties should an action tokenizer satisfy to serve as a policy interface?

In this paper, we study *what constitutes good action tokens* and argue that an effective action tokenizer must simultaneously satisfy three key desiderata: high compression, total decodability, and ordered token structure. **(1) High compression** keeps token sequences compact. **(2) Total decodability** ensures that arbitrary policy outputs map to executable actions when tokens are decoded. **(3) Ordered structure** places control-relevant information early, implicitly forming a coarse-to-fine representation.

Prior action tokenization methods satisfy subsets of these desiderata, but not all simultaneously. Per-dimension binning (Bin) is simple and reliably decodable, but it serializes every action dimension at every step, producing long token sequences as action dimension and prediction horizon grow (Brohan et al., 2023; Zitkovich et al., 2023; Kim et al., 2024). Frequency-domain tokenizers such as FAST introduce a useful low-to-high-frequency order, but byte-pair encoding compression makes detokenization only partially defined: an unconstrained policy sample is not guaranteed to expand into the fixed-shape coefficient array required for control (Gage, 1994; Sennrich et al., 2016; Pertsch et al., 2025). Learned latent tokenizers such as QueST and ACodec compress action chunks through discrete bottlenecks (Mete et al., 2024; Lee et al., 2024; Dong et al., 2026), but the reconstruction quality they optimize for does not necessarily improve closed-loop policy rollout success at inference.

To bridge this gap, we propose Ordered Action Tokenization (**OAT**), a learned tokenizer that discretizes continuous action chunks into compact, totally decodable, and ordered token sequences. **OAT** employs transformer-based register tokens to aggregate temporal information, finite scalar quantization to construct a discrete bottleneck, and nested dropout to train every token prefix to decode into a plausible action chunk. This prefix training implicitly induces a coarse-to-fine structure: early tokens capture high-impact control information, while later tokens refine residual detail.

We validate the effectiveness of **OAT** in two prevailing uses of action tokens. In autoregressive policies, **OAT** tokens are generated and detokenized into actions; their ordering provides an inductive bias aligned with next-token prediction and supports variable inference budgets through prefix-based decoding. In token co-training policies, action token losses supervise the vision-language model (VLM), whose context conditions a flow-matching action expert at inference; **OAT** turns this supervision into a structured signal rather than an arbitrary latent serialization. Sec. 2 gives the background for both policy roles.

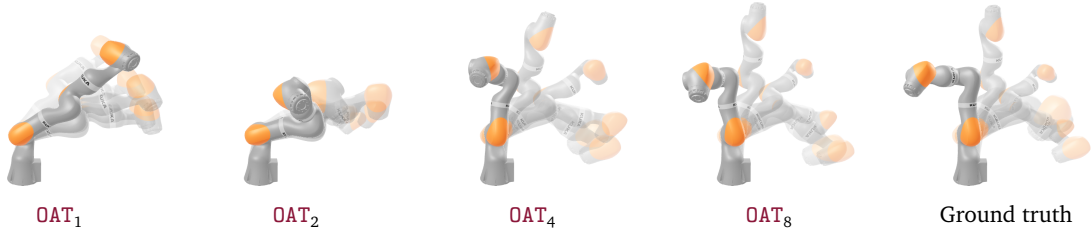


Figure 2: Prefix reconstruction on an iiwa arm. Columns show action chunk reconstructions decoded from the first 1, 2, 4, and 8 **OAT** tokens, followed by the ground-truth action chunk. Increasing the prefix budget progressively refines the reconstructed trajectory while every mask-padded prefix detokenizes to an executable action chunk. See the [interactive prefix lab](#) on the project website.

For scalable autoregressive inference with **OAT**, we further introduce block-wise autoregression (BAR), a *scheduling* framework that unifies token-wise autoregression, one-shot parallel decoding, fixed-size block prediction (Liu et al., 2026; Dong et al., 2026), and intermediate schemes. We focus on two variants in this paper: **OAT**^{sing} for token-wise autoregression and **OAT**^{pow2} for BAR with power-of-two scheduling, where the latter reduces inference complexity from linear to logarithmic.

Contributions. In summary, this paper makes three contributions, as illustrated in Fig. 1:

1. We analyze representative action tokenizers as policy interfaces and formalize three desiderata for visuomotor policy learning: high compression, total decodability, and ordered structure.
2. We propose **OAT**, a learned action tokenizer that satisfies these desiderata with compact, totally decodable, ordered tokens whose prefixes decode to executable action chunks, and further introduce BAR as a framework for scalable autoregressive inference.
3. We conduct extensive experiments and ablations showing that **OAT** is effective across lightweight policies and vision-language-action (VLA)-scale systems, covering both autoregressive (AR) policies that generate action tokens and token co-training (TC) policies that use action tokens as supervision.

2 Preliminaries

We first define notation and background used throughout the paper.

Action chunks and tokens. Robot policies commonly execute control through short chunks of continuous actions. We write one action chunk as

$$A = a_{1:H_a} \in \mathbb{R}^{H_a \times D_a},$$

where H_a is the action horizon and D_a is the action dimension. Tokenized autoregressive policies expose this continuous chunk as a discrete sequence of policy symbols (Brohan et al., 2023; Zitkovich et al., 2023; Kim et al., 2024; Bonatti et al., 2022; Fu et al., 2025). For a tokenizer setting with token horizon H_l , the action tokenizer is

$$\mathcal{T} : a_{1:H_a} \mapsto T_{1:H_l}, \quad T_i \in \mathcal{V}.$$

Here $\mathcal{V}$ is the action token vocabulary. A corresponding detokenizer, written as $\mathcal{T}^{-1}$ for notation, maps a token sequence back to a continuous action chunk,

$$\mathcal{T}^{-1} : T_{1:H_l} \mapsto \hat{a}_{1:H_a}.$$

Token-wise autoregressive policies. Let $o_{1:H_o}$ denote the observation history available to the policy, with observation horizon H_o . The standard token-wise autoregressive policy models the action token sequence left to right:

$$p_\pi(T_{1:H_l} | o_{1:H_o}) = \prod_{i=1}^{H_l} p_\pi(T_i | T_{<i}, o_{1:H_o}).$$

After sampling $T_{1:H_l}$, the policy detokenizes it with $\mathcal{T}^{-1}$ and executes the resulting chunk, typically using receding-horizon control (Zhao et al., 2023; Chi et al., 2025; Zhang et al., 2025). Sec. 5.1 introduces BAR, which keeps this tokenizer–detokenizer interface but groups token positions during generation instead of generating one position at a time.

Token co-training policies. We use *token co-training* to denote a VLA training setup that separates token-based VLM supervision from continuous action prediction (Driess et al., 2025; Black et al., 2025; Dong et al., 2026). During training, an action token loss supervises the VLM, while a flow-matching loss trains a separate action expert conditioned on detached VLM context (Driess et al., 2025; Dong et al., 2026). Its objective has the schematic form

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{TC}} = \mathcal{L}_{\text{tok}} + \lambda \mathcal{L}_{\text{flow}},$$

where the token loss provides action supervision to the VLM, whereas the flow loss trains the expert without propagating through the detached context. At inference, the token prediction branch is removed, and the expert generates continuous action chunks from cached VLM context. Action tokens therefore serve as supervision targets rather than the representation executed by the controller. Sec. 5.2 instantiates this interface with OAT.

3 Action Tokenization as a Policy Interface

Following the notation in Sec. 2, this section analyzes what makes an action tokenizer a useful policy interface. The tokenizer determines the discrete targets presented to the policy, how many targets it must model, whether arbitrary generated sequences can be detokenized into valid actions, and how token structure interacts with the policy objective.

3.1 Tokenizer Desiderata

Rate and distortion are a general lens for lossy compression (Shannon, 1948; Blau and Michaeli, 2019) and are widely used to analyze learned discrete representations (Tschannen et al., 2018; van den Oord et al., 2017; Mentzer et al., 2024; Bachmann et al., 2025; Zhao et al., 2025). For action tokenization, compression remains a policy requirement because long token sequences increase the number of prediction targets and, for autoregressive policies, generation depth. Policy learning also adds requirements that compression alone does not capture: sampled tokens must decode reliably, and token order should expose control structure that helps policies generate tokens or learn from token supervision.

P1 High compression. The token horizon H_l should be small relative to the raw action size $H_a D_a$. Long token sequences increase training difficulty and, for autoregressive policies, inference latency because the policy must model more token targets and generate more tokens. A suitable tokenizer keeps the rate low while preserving motion relevant to control.

P2 Total decodability. The detokenizer should be a total function over the policy’s discrete output space. When tokens are decoded into control, a policy can emit any token sequence supported by its output distribution. The detokenizer must therefore map arbitrary policy samples, not only training codes produced by the encoder, to valid continuous actions.

Scheme	Compact	Total decodable	Ordered structure	Block compat.	Policy implication
Bin [12, 82]	✗	✓	✗	✓	Long coordinate sequences raise inference cost and give weak conditioning structure.
FAST [60]	✓	✗	✓	✗	Unconstrained samples can decode invalidly; constrained decoding changes the policy interface.
QueST [54]	✓	✓	✗	✗	A reconstruction loss need not place control-relevant information early.
ACodec [20]	✓	✓	—	✓	Parallel decoding does not require serial ordering, but the full latent block is a hard joint target.
OAT ^{sing} [49]	✓	✓	✓	✗	Ordered token-wise targets satisfy the core interface, but grouped block prediction requires matched training.
OAT ^{pow2}	✓	✓	✓	✓	Matched budgets and block-causal attention make block prediction a trained target.

Table 1: Action tokenizer comparison. Rows compare representative action tokenizers as policy interfaces. The first three columns mark the core desiderata: compactness, total decodability over unconstrained policy samples, and ordered token structure. The final column records block compatibility, a side property for scalable grouped autoregressive inference. A dash marks one-shot parallel decoding, where serial ordered structure is not applicable.

P3 Ordered token structure. Reconstruction error alone does not guarantee useful policy targets. An ordered token structure places control-relevant information early and leaves residual detail to later tokens. For autoregressive policies, this creates learnable generation targets; for token co-training policies, it can provide a structured supervision signal rather than an arbitrary latent serialization. Many such orders are possible; for example, a coarse-to-fine order places high-impact motion early and leaves later tokens to refine residual detail.

Block compatibility. Block-wise generation is not a core tokenizer desideratum, but it is useful for scalable autoregressive inference. As formalized in Sec. 5.1, a BAR pattern can ask the policy to emit several new tokens at the same prefix budget in a single call (Stern et al., 2018). Those tokens must be jointly predictable from the observation, the realized prefix, and prediction masks, without relying on realized within-block tokens as serial inputs. A compact, total, ordered tokenizer can still fail this property if its token structure was trained only as a strict token-wise chain. Table 1 summarizes how the tokenizers discussed in the paper satisfy these interface properties; the final rows show the token-wise and power-of-two OAT variants defined in Sec. 4.4.

3.2 Where Existing Tokenizers Fall Short

Existing action tokenizers satisfy different parts of this interface, but no standard baseline satisfies the three core desiderata while also providing block compatibility as shown in Table 1. Per-dimension Bin is reliable because every generated bin index maps back to a scalar action value, and coordinate groups can be decoded into valid actions. Its cost is rate and ordering: the token horizon grows with $H_a D_a$, and the manual coordinate serialization does not place coarse trajectory information early in the sequence.

FAST addresses rate and ordering by representing action trajectories through frequency-domain coefficients and then applying byte-pair encoding (BPE). Low-frequency components appear before high-frequency components, so early tokens tend to describe coarse motion. The difficulty is that byte-pair encoding expands tokens into variable-length coefficient streams, while the inverse frequency transform expects a fixed coefficient topology. Unconstrained policy samples can therefore decode invalidly or require padding, truncation, rejection, or constrained decoding, each of which

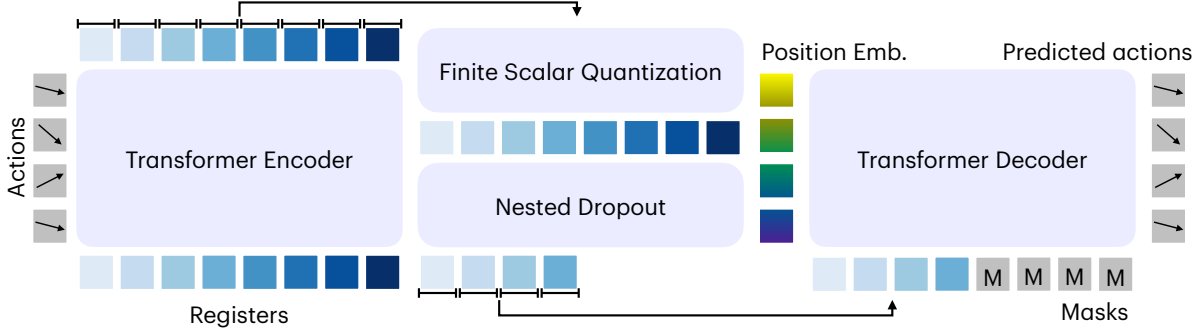


Figure 3: OAT tokenizer pipeline. OAT encodes a continuous action chunk with register tokens, discretizes the register states with finite scalar quantization, and trains a decoder to reconstruct the full action chunk from retained token prefixes. Nested dropout samples budgets and replaces suffixes with learned masks, forcing early tokens to carry coarse executable control while later tokens refine residual detail.

changes the policy interface.

Learned latent tokenizers such as QueST and ACodec use vector-quantized or finite-scalar-quantized (Mentzer et al., 2024) bottlenecks that decode through learned latent spaces. QueST-style sequential latents are attractive from a rate–distortion viewpoint, but training for reconstruction alone need not make early tokens useful for generation or structured supervision. ACodec instead predicts fixed latent blocks jointly, reducing serial depth but making each block a harder joint prediction problem.

Thus reconstruction quality alone does not determine whether an action tokenizer is a good policy interface: the representation must also be compact, total over policy samples, and ordered for generation and supervision. For scalable autoregressive inference, compatibility with the intended BAR block pattern is an additional side property. A detailed discussion of these baseline tokenizers is provided in Appendix D.

4 OAT: Ordered Action Tokenization

The tokenizer analysis above motivates OAT as a tokenizer for compact, totally decodable, ordered representations. This section defines the encoder–quantizer–decoder backbone, the ordered prefix training objective, and the token-wise and power-of-two variants studied in this paper.

4.1 Tokenization $\mathcal{T}$ and Detokenization $\mathcal{T}^{-1}$

OAT maps a continuous action chunk to a sequence of discrete action tokens and decodes token sequences back to continuous control. The tokenizer $\mathcal{T}$ is instantiated by an encoder E_ϕ and a quantization bottleneck, while the detokenizer $\mathcal{T}^{-1}$ is instantiated by a decoder D_θ , as summarized in Fig. 3. This autoencoder architecture ensures total decodability for the policy interface: every vocabulary index sequence maps to a continuous action chunk. We next describe the bottleneck design that gives OAT its compact and ordered token structure.

Register bottleneck. The encoder uses learnable registers $r_{1:H_l}$, inspired by ViT registers (Darcet et al., 2024), to compress a continuous action chunk $a_{1:H_a}$ into a fixed sequence of register states. Each register cross-attends (Vaswani et al., 2017) to all action positions, and the ordered prefix objective in the next subsection specifies the register self-attention mask. The encoder returns the register states $z_{1:H_l} = E_\phi(a_{1:H_a}, r_{1:H_l})$. Each latent $z_i \in \mathbb{R}^{D_l}$ is discretized into token T_i using finite scalar quantization (FSQ) (Mentzer et al., 2024). The resulting token sequence $T_{1:H_l}$ serves as the token target for policy learning. The finite scalar quantization levels determine the vocabulary size, and H_l determines how many action tokens the policy must predict.

The decoder is a cross-attention Transformer: action position embeddings query the quantized register tokens and are projected into the H_a output actions, with no self-attention among action position queries. Next, we discuss training **OAT** with an ordered prefix objective.

4.2 Ordered Prefix Training for Progressive Tokens

Effective action tokenization requires more than compact reconstruction: the token sequence should have an order that policies can exploit. Our goal is to make early tokens capture coarse, globally salient aspects of an action chunk, while later tokens refine residual details. We use two complementary mechanisms to induce this ordering and support variable token budgets.

Nested Prefix Reconstruction **OAT** induces order through an increasing list of reconstruction budgets. Let $\mathbf{b} = (b_0, b_1, \dots, b_S)$ denote the budget list, with $0 = b_0 < b_1 < \dots < b_S = H_l$. Adjacent endpoints define the token groups $G_s = T_{b_{s-1}+1:b_s}$. During tokenizer training, we sample a budget $B \in \{b_1, \dots, b_S\}$, retain only the prefix $T_{1:B}$, and replace the suffix with learned mask tokens $\langle \text{MASK} \rangle$ before decoding. This produces the masked decoder input

$$\tilde{T}_{1:H_l}^{(B)} = T_{1:B} \oplus \langle \text{MASK} \rangle_{B+1:H_l}.$$

The decoder must reconstruct the full action chunk from this partial code:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{prefix}} = \mathbb{E}_{a,B} \left[\left\| D_{\theta}(\tilde{T}_{1:H_l}^{(B)}) - a_{1:H_a} \right\|_2^2 \right].$$

This is nested dropout over action tokens (Rippel et al., 2014; Kusupati et al., 2022; Cai et al., 2025; Bachmann et al., 2025). Unlike an autoencoder objective trained only on full token sequences, it trains every sampled prefix as an executable reconstruction point. The same endpoints can later define generated blocks for grouped autoregressive inference; ordered prefix training itself only requires that the selected budgets decode. [Algo. 1](#) summarizes this tokenizer training loop.

Register Flow Constraints The register self-attention mask supplies the architectural constraint that matches this prefix objective. In the token-wise variant, registers use ordinary causal attention, so each token extends the previous prefix by one position. In the power-of-two variant, registers can read earlier budget groups and themselves, while accesses to other registers in the same newly introduced group are blocked. This keeps every trained budget prefix progressive and prevents tokens added at the same budget from depending on one another through direct register attention paths. [Fig. 4](#) visualizes the token-wise and power-of-two masks.

4.3 Progressive Information Allocation

The two mechanisms above give token ordering a source-coding-inspired information allocation interpretation. In classical source coding, common source patterns can be represented with shorter expected descriptions (Shannon, 1948). Here, the analogue of code length is the number of retained action tokens. Let $\varepsilon(K)$ denote the expected reconstruction error when only the first K tokens are retained, with $\varepsilon(0)$ denoting the all-mask error, and let $\Delta_i = \varepsilon(i-1) - \varepsilon(i)$ be the marginal gain from retaining token i . The expected nested dropout objective expands as

$$\mathbb{E}_B[\varepsilon(B)] = \varepsilon(0) - \sum_{i=1}^{H_l} \mathbb{P}(B \geq i) \Delta_i.$$

Thus token i is weighted by its survival probability $w_i = \mathbb{P}(B \geq i)$. Since w_i is nonincreasing in i , early tokens are optimized under more reconstruction budgets than later tokens. This weighting pressure favors placing larger marginal gains earlier in the sequence. In practice, early tokens

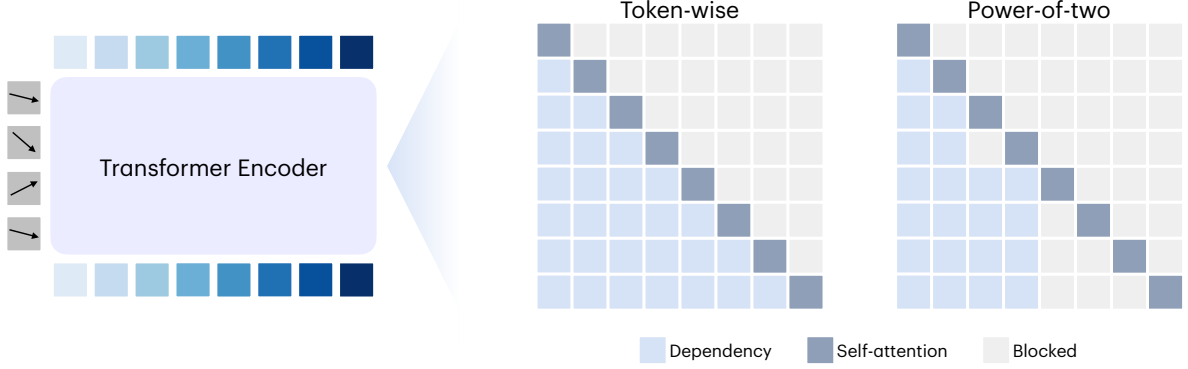


Figure 4: OAT encoder attention masks. Each matrix entry at row i and column j indicates whether register i can attend to register j . The token-wise mask gives causal register attention. The power-of-two mask preserves attention to earlier budget groups and self-attention, while blocking other registers in the same new group. The action inputs, registers, quantizer, nested dropout, and decoder remain unchanged.

are encouraged to encode information that is broadly useful across action chunks, such as coarse trajectory structure, while later tokens spend capacity on residual refinements and details that are useful after the coarse structure is available. The ordering is therefore not manually assigned to coordinates, timesteps, or frequencies; it is induced by the pressure to optimize executable prefixes under variable information budgets.

This view also motivates our diagnostics. For a fixed retained prefix length K , the token budget is a proxy for rate¹, and distortion is the reconstruction error $\varepsilon(K)$ defined above. Autoencoders trained only on full token sequences optimize only the endpoint $\varepsilon(H_l)$. OAT instead trains and evaluates this curve at multiple budgets $K \in \{b_1, \dots, b_s\}$. Fig. 2 gives a qualitative example of prefix refinement, and Fig. 7 later quantifies whether the learned prefixes reduce distortion smoothly as the token budget increases. The ordering ablation in Fig. 10 further tests whether this learned ordering is important for downstream policy performance.

4.4 Token-Wise and Power-of-Two Variants

The budget list is the only component that changes across the OAT variants used in our experiments. It sets the nested dropout budgets, the register self-attention mask, and the resulting token budget groups.

Token-wise variant. OAT^{sing} is the token-wise instantiation with $b_s = s$. It trains every prefix length and uses ordinary causal register attention, so each token extends the previous prefix by one position.

Power-of-two variant. OAT^{pow2} is the power-of-two instantiation with budgets $(1, 2, 4, 8, \dots)$. The tokenizer samples reconstruction points only at those budgets and uses the block-causal register mask in Fig. 4. For $H_l = 16$ in our VLM experiments, the trained budgets are 1, 2, 4, 8, 16 with $b_0 = 0$. Under the information allocation view above, all token positions introduced at the same endpoint b_m share the survival weight $\mathbb{P}(B \geq b_m)$. OAT^{pow2} therefore imposes ordering across budget groups, while the prefix objective does not impose an additional priority order among tokens introduced within the same budget group.

Together, these variants define ordered token sequences whose prefixes decode at the trained budgets. We next describe how visuomotor policies use this token interface for generation and supervision.

¹The corresponding code length is proportional to $K \log_2(|\mathcal{C}|)$, where $\mathcal{C}$ is the quantization codebook.

Algorithm 1: OAT tokenizer training. Encode an action chunk, mask the suffix at a sampled budget, and reconstruct from the prefix.

Input: dataset $\mathcal{D}$; encoder E_ϕ ; registers $r_{1:H_l}$; FSQ; decoder D_θ ; mask token MASK; budget list $\mathbf{b}$; sampling distribution $p(m)$.

1. **while** not converged **do**
2. Sample $a_{1:H_a} \sim \mathcal{D}$ and $m \sim p(m)$.
3. $z_{1:H_l} \leftarrow E_\phi(a_{1:H_a}, r_{1:H_l}; \mathbf{b})$.
4. $T_{1:H_l} \leftarrow \text{FSQ}(z_{1:H_l})$.
5. $\tilde{T} \leftarrow T_{1:b_m} \oplus \langle \text{MASK} \rangle_{b_m+1:H_l}$.
6. $\hat{a}_{1:H_a} \leftarrow D_\theta(\tilde{T})$.
7. Update $\{\phi, \theta, r, \text{MASK}\}$ on $\|\hat{a}_{1:H_a} - a_{1:H_a}\|_2^2$.
8. **end while**
9. **return** $\mathcal{T}$ and $\mathcal{T}^{-1}$.

Algorithm 2: Autoregressive OAT generation. Generate tokens up to a target budget, mask the suffix, and return the decoded action chunk.

Input: observation history $o_{1:H_o}$; action token policy π ; $\mathcal{T}^{-1} = \{D_\theta, \text{MASK}\}$; trained budget list $\mathbf{b} = (b_0 = 0, \dots, b_m = K)$ with $g_s = b_s - b_{s-1}$.

1. Initialize $\hat{T}_{1:0} \leftarrow \emptyset$ and $g_0 \leftarrow 0$.
2. **for** $s = 1, \dots, m$ **do**
3. $\hat{X}^{(s)} \leftarrow \hat{T}_{1:b_{s-1}} \oplus \langle \text{MASK} \rangle^{g_s - g_{s-1}}$.
4. $p_s(\cdot) \leftarrow \pi(\cdot | \hat{X}^{(s)}, o_{1:H_o})$.
5. Sample $\hat{G}_s$ from the final g_s logit-read slots.
6. $\hat{T}_{1:b_s} \leftarrow \hat{T}_{1:b_{s-1}} \oplus \hat{G}_s$.
7. **end for**
8. $\tilde{T} \leftarrow \hat{T}_{1:K} \oplus \langle \text{MASK} \rangle_{K+1:H_l}$.
9. **return** action chunk $\hat{a}_{1:H_a} = \mathcal{T}^{-1}(\tilde{T})$.

5 OAT for Visuomotor Policies

We instantiate OAT in the two policy interfaces introduced in Sec. 2. In autoregressive control, BAR specifies how ordered token positions are grouped into policy calls, while OAT provides the progressive, prefix-decodable action representation. In token co-training, the full OAT sequence supervises the VLM during training, while a flow-matching expert generates continuous action chunks from detached VLM context. The following subsections develop these interfaces in turn.

5.1 Block-wise Autoregressive OAT Generation

In the autoregressive role, a policy must choose how many action tokens to predict per policy call. We formulate BAR as a generation schedule over a fixed-length token sequence $T_{1:H_l}$. An endpoint list $\mathbf{b} = (b_0, b_1, \dots, b_S)$, with $0 = b_0 < b_1 < \dots < b_S = H_l$, partitions the sequence into blocks $G_s = T_{b_{s-1}+1:b_s}$ of size $g_s = b_s - b_{s-1}$. Stage s predicts G_s in one policy call conditioned on the realized prefix $T_{1:b_{s-1}}$. Thus S sets the sequential policy depth, while g_s sets the number of tokens predicted in parallel. Token-wise autoregression, fixed-size block prediction (Liu et al., 2026; Dong et al., 2026), one-shot parallel decoding (Dong et al., 2026), and intermediate variable-size patterns are all special cases, as illustrated in Fig. 5.

For the power-of-two horizons considered here, $H_l = 2^{S-1}$, we use endpoints $(1, 2, 4, \dots, H_l)$ to preserve more serial conditioning for early tokens while increasing parallelism at later stages. Full generation then requires $S = 1 + \log_2 H_l$ policy calls, reducing the depth from $O(H_l)$ to $O(\log H_l)$. Appendix A shows that this depth is minimal when each new block is no larger than the realized prefix.

To train a nondecreasing schedule $g_1 \leq \dots \leq g_S$, we set $T_{1:b_0} = \emptyset$ and $g_0 = 0$, and use the block-shifted input

$$X^{(s)} = T_{1:b_{s-1}} \oplus \langle \text{MASK} \rangle^{g_s - g_{s-1}}.$$

The final g_s positions provide the logit-read slots for predicting the current block G_s . For $s > 1$, these slots comprise the previous block G_{s-1} followed by $g_s - g_{s-1}$ new masks; at $s = 1$, they contain g_1 masks. Let $p_{\pi,j}^{(s)}(\cdot | X^{(s)}, o)$ denote the categorical distribution read from the j -th such slot under

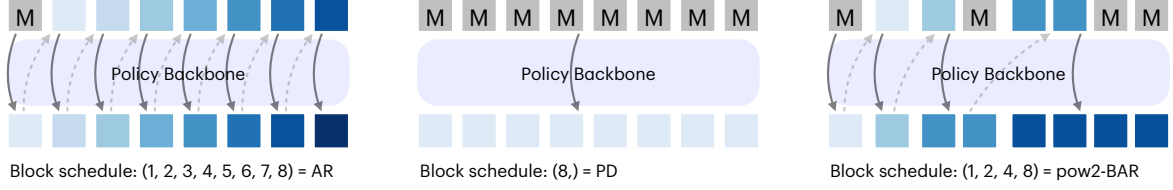


Figure 5: BAR block patterns. BAR generates action tokens block by block according to an endpoint list. For action token horizon $H_l = 8$, token-wise autoregression uses endpoints (1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8), parallel decoding uses endpoint (8), and the power-of-two pattern uses endpoints (1, 2, 4, 8). Gray tokens marked “M” are masks, and blue tokens are newly predicted action tokens.

policy π and observation context o . The training objective is

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{BAR}} = - \sum_{s=1}^S \sum_{j=1}^{g_s} \log p_{\pi,j}^{(s)}(T_{b_{s-1}+j} | X^{(s)}, o).$$

This objective produces all g_s logits in one policy forward pass without exposing ground-truth tokens from G_s . At inference, the same construction uses the generated prefix and appends the predicted block $\hat{G}_s$ after each call.

OAT training and BAR generation share the endpoint list $\mathbf{b}$: each positive endpoint b_s , for $s \in \{1, \dots, S\}$, is both a tokenizer reconstruction budget and the end of a generated block. The token-wise variant **OAT**^{sing} uses $b_s = s$, requiring K policy calls for a length- K prefix. The power-of-two variant **OAT**^{pow2} uses endpoints (1, 2, 4, 8, 16) for $H_l = 16$, requiring five calls for complete generation. At any trained endpoint, the generated prefix can be suffix-padded with learned mask tokens and decoded immediately, or generation can continue to a larger budget. [Algo. 2](#) and [Appendix A](#) provide the full inference procedure and BAR specification.

5.2 Token Co-Training with **OAT**

In the token co-training role, **OAT** tokens supervise the VLM rather than being decoded into actions. Let c denote the image, language, and robot state context. Given a frozen tokenizer $\mathcal{T}$, each training action chunk $a_{1:H_a}$ defines a target sequence $T_{1:H_l} = \mathcal{T}(a_{1:H_a})$. The VLM predicts this sequence under teacher forcing, while the action expert learns from the same action chunk and a detached VLM key/value (K/V) cache. Their joint objective is ([Driess et al., 2025](#); [Dong et al., 2026](#))

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{TC}} = \mathcal{L}_{\text{tok}}(T_{1:H_l} | c) + \lambda \mathcal{L}_{\text{flow}}(a_{1:H_a}, \tilde{a}_{1:H_a}^\tau, \tau; \text{sg}(\text{KV}_{\text{VLM}}(c))), \quad (5.1)$$

where $\mathcal{L}_{\text{tok}}$ is the cross-entropy for predicting each T_i from c and the shifted ground-truth prefix $\langle \text{MASK} \rangle, T_{1:i-1}$. The leading mask supplies the prediction slot for T_1 . The term $\tilde{a}_{1:H_a}^\tau$ denotes the noised action chunk at flow time τ , and $\text{sg}(\cdot)$ denotes stop-gradient. The layer-wise cache $\text{KV}_{\text{VLM}}(c)$ is computed from the image, language, and robot state prefill only, excluding the teacher-forced action token positions.

The two losses follow separate gradient paths. The token loss provides action supervision to the VLM, whereas the flow loss trains the action expert without propagating through the detached cache. At inference, the VLM is prefilled once on c , the token branch is omitted, and the flow-matching expert generates a continuous action chunk from the cached context for execution. No action tokens are generated or detokenized during execution.

Token co-training uses the full **OAT** sequence under teacher forcing; neither BAR generation nor the **OAT** decoder is used by the policy. The tokenizer instead determines the supervision presented

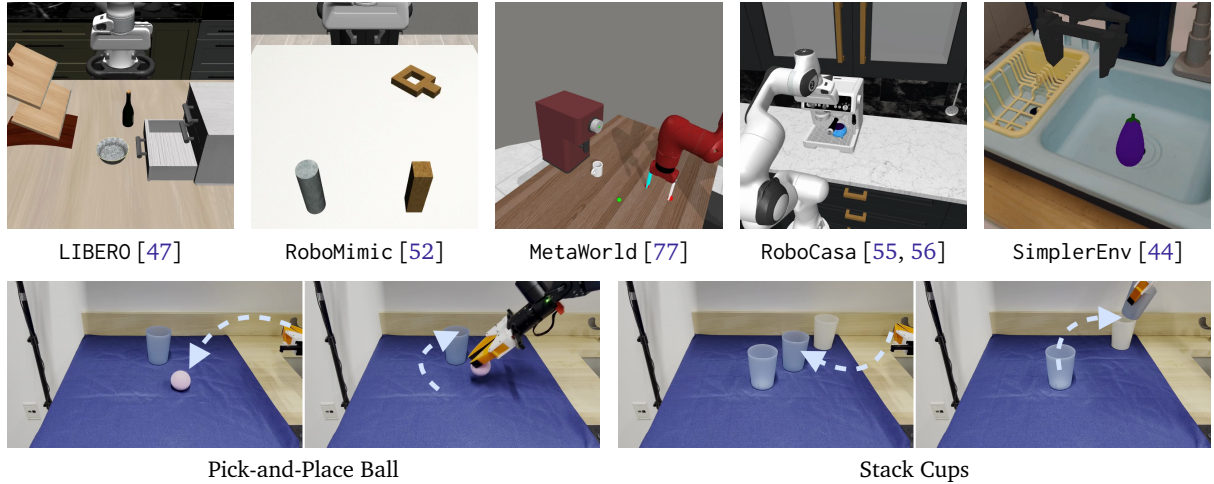


Figure 6: Evaluation environments. **Top row:** simulated manipulation benchmarks used for lightweight policies, VLM AR policies, and VLM TC policies. **Bottom row:** real-world tabletop tasks evaluated with a fixed-base ARX-5 arm and a single Logitech webcam; each filmstrip shows one representative rollout.

to the VLM. Through its ordering mechanisms, **OAT** assigns coarse action structure to early targets and residual refinements to later targets. Earlier targets have shorter teacher-forced prefixes and therefore depend more directly on the VLM context, whereas later targets can condition on longer prefixes. **OAT** thus aligns the supervision hierarchy with the conditional structure of token prediction rather than presenting an arbitrary latent serialization. [Sec. 6.5.2](#) evaluates this supervision against alternative action tokenizers; [Appendix B](#) provides further flow-matching and inference details.

6 Experiments

Experiments assess **OAT** at three levels of the action token interface. We begin at the tokenizer level in [Sec. 6.3](#), testing whether **OAT** forms a compact, progressive action representation whose prefixes remain executable rather than only optimizing full-sequence reconstruction. We then move to closed-loop policy learning: [Sec. 6.4](#) evaluates lightweight autoregressive policies, while [Secs. 6.5.1](#) and [6.5.2](#) study VLM-scale policies under autoregressive (AR) generation and token co-training (TC). Finally, [Sec. 6.6](#) analyzes token ordering, action and token horizons, codebook capacity, and schedule-matched grouped generation to clarify the design choices behind **OAT**.

6.1 Evaluation Regimes and Benchmarks

We organize evaluation by policy scale. The lightweight regime uses the same Transformer policy for every method, so comparisons focus on action representation, token budget, and AR generation pattern. This regime covers LIBERO-Long ([Liu et al., 2023](#)), RoboMimic ([Mandlekar et al., 2022](#)), MetaWorld ([Yu et al., 2020](#)), RoboCasa ([Nasiriany et al., 2024](#)), and two real-world tabletop tasks.

The VLM regime evaluates the same action token interfaces with VLM backbones in two roles: AR policies generate tokens for execution, while TC policies use token losses as VLM supervision. This regime covers LIBERO suites, RoboMimic, SimplrEnv ([Li et al., 2025](#)), and RoboCasa365 ([Nasiriany et al., 2026](#)).

Within each comparison block, methods share the observation interface, data split, rollout protocol, and policy backbone. The varied factors are the action representation and, for AR policies, the generation pattern; VLM TC comparisons instead vary the token supervision while leaving inference to the flow-matching expert. [Fig. 6](#) shows the evaluation settings. [Table 2](#) summarizes benchmark

Setting	Benchmark	Tasks / suites	# Tasks	$H_a \times D_a$	Freq. (Hz)	Med. len.
Lightweight	LIBERO	Long suite	10	32×7	10	259
	RoboMimic	Lift; Square; Can	3	32×7	20	114
	MetaWorld	Box Close; Coffee Pull; Disassemble; Stick Pull	4	32×4	80	72
	RoboCasa	Close Drawer; Coffee Press Button; Turn Off Microwave; Turn Off Sink Faucet	4	32×12	20	184
	Real-world	Pick-and-Place Ball; Stack Cups	2	32×7	10	98
VLM	LIBERO	Long, Goal, Object, and Spatial suites	40	32×7	10	140
	RoboMimic	Lift; Square; Can; Tool Hang	4	32×7	20	130
	SimplerEnv	WidowX+Bridge series	4	8×7	5	37
	RoboCasa365	Close Toaster Oven Door; Open Drawer; Pick Place Drawer to Counter; Turn On Electric Kettle; Slide Dishwasher Rack	5	32×12	20	194

Table 2: Benchmark setup. Rows summarize the simulated and real-world settings used for policy evaluation. $H_a \times D_a$ gives the predicted action horizon and action dimension; Med. len. is the median episode length in environment steps. Task subsets differ by evaluation regime as listed. The lightweight regime fixes a Transformer policy, while the VLM regime uses the backbones in Table 3; within each regime, tokenizer comparisons keep the policy backbone fixed.

Backbone	Scale	Interface	Ctx. attn.	Act. attn.
Transformer	5M	Cross-attn.	Cross	Causal
PaliGemma2 [66]	3B	Prefix VLM	Full	Causal
Qwen3VL [4]	2B	Causal VLM	Causal	Causal

Table 3: Policy backbone interfaces. Rows define the backbone attention interfaces used in later comparisons. Ctx. attn. covers observation, language, and state tokens; Act. attn. covers generated action tokens.

splits, action dimensions, control frequencies, and episode lengths. Table 3 specifies the backbone attention interface, and Table 4 specifies the tokenizer, generation pattern, and policy-call count.

6.2 Experimental Protocol and Implementation

This subsection specifies the rollout metric, tokenizer configurations, and policy implementation shared across the lightweight and VLM regimes. Optimizer settings are summarized in Appendix C; the TC computation graph and flow-matching details are given in Appendix B.

Rollout protocol. We fix implementation details so that the action representation remains the primary experimental variable. Unless otherwise specified, simulated tasks use 50 evaluation episodes per task and report mean success rate; real-world tasks use 20 independent rollouts and report completed trials. Within each environment, all methods use the same benchmark split, rollout horizon, and success criterion. Policies predict contiguous action chunks with benchmark-specific action dimension D_a . All benchmarks use action horizon $H_a = 32$, except SimplerEnv, which uses $H_a = 8$. At test time, only the first half of each predicted chunk is executed before the policy is queried again (Zhao et al., 2023; Chi et al., 2025; Zhang et al., 2025). Because success rates are finite rollout estimates, we interpret very small gaps as practical ties and emphasize consistent trends and benchmark-level differences rather than rank changes from small margins.

Compared tokenizers. The tokenizer comparison covers the main design choices from Sec. 3. (1) Bin discretizes each action dimension into $N = 256$ uniform bins, producing a long sequence that maps back to an action chunk up to scalar quantization, with length scaling as $H_a D_a$ following the scalar action discretization used by Brohan et al. (2023), Zitkovich et al. (2023), and Kim et al.

Scheme	Tokenizer training	Generation	# Calls	Max block
Bin	Raw coordinate bins	stepwise D_a blocks	H_a	D_a
FAST	DCT+BPE coefficients	token-wise BPE sequence	$ T $	1
QueST	Learned temporal latents	token-wise latent sequence	H_l	1
ACodec	Joint latent block	one-shot latent block	1	H_l
$\text{OAT}_k^{\text{sing}}$	token-wise training	token-wise AR	k	1
$\text{OAT}_k^{\text{pow2}}$	power-of-two training	power-of-two BAR	$1 + \lceil \log_2 k \rceil$	$\lceil k/2 \rceil$

Table 4: Action token budget and generation settings. Rows compare each tokenizer setting, generation pattern, and call cost. # Calls is the number of sequential policy calls for one action chunk, and Max block is the largest action token block generated in one policy call. For the OAT rows, k denotes the executable prefix budget; OAT^{pow2} uses power-of-two budgets and block-causal register attention. For FAST, $|T|$ denotes generated BPE length.

(2024). (2) FAST (Pertsch et al., 2025) applies the universal FAST tokenizer with vocabulary size 2048, giving a compact frequency-domain representation. (3) QueST (Mete et al., 2024) compresses action chunks with a temporal convolution of downsample factor 2 before learned tokenization. (4) ACodec (Dong et al., 2026) uses learnable registers that cross-attend to the action chunk without attending to one another, forming a one-shot parallel decoding endpoint. OAT summarizes action chunks with learnable registers and ordered partial codes. We evaluate the token-wise and power-of-two training settings defined in Sec. 4.4.

For FAST, arbitrary samples from AR policies may expand to a coefficient stream whose length differs from the fixed topology required by the inverse transform, as discussed in Sec. 3. In all simulated rollouts, we report *nonstrict* FAST decoding unless otherwise specified: after BPE expansion, the coefficient stream is padded or truncated to the expected length before the inverse discrete cosine transform (DCT). This ensures every generated FAST sequence can be converted into an action chunk during simulated rollouts, but it can silently shift frequency coefficients. For physical rollouts, we instead use *strict* decoding: if a generated FAST token sequence is not decodable, the action chunk is rejected, and the policy is queried again.

For fair comparison among learned chunk tokenizers, QueST, ACodec, and the OAT variants use the same encoder and decoder capacity: 6 transformer layers, 8 attention heads, and model dimension 256. For QueST and OAT , we use FSQ with levels $[8, 8, 6, 5]$, corresponding to $8 \times 8 \times 6 \times 5 = 1920 \approx 2048$ discrete codes (Mentzer et al., 2024). For ACodec, we follow the official implementation and use vector quantization with latent dimension 512 and codebook size 2048.

Policy implementation. The lightweight AR policy uses the Transformer backbone: image and robot state observations enter through cross-attention, and the model predicts action token logits directly. VLM policies instead place observation, language, and state tokens in the language model context and attach an action token suffix. To make action codes valid VLM outputs for both VLM AR generation and VLM TC supervision, we extend each VLM tokenizer with the special token set $\mathcal{S}_{\text{act}}$:

$$\mathcal{S}_{\text{act}} = \{ \langle \text{action}_i \rangle : i \in [|\mathcal{V}_a|] \} \cup \{ \langle \text{action_mask} \rangle \}.$$

Each $\langle \text{action}_i \rangle$ maps to one discrete action code, and $\langle \text{action_mask} \rangle$ supplies the mask symbol for BAR. Backbone attention follows Table 3: prefix VLM backbones such as PaliGemma2 use full attention over context tokens and causal attention over action suffix tokens, while causal VLM backbones such as Qwen3VL use causal attention over both context and action suffix tokens.

AR and TC policies differ in how this suffix is used. In VLM AR policies, the action suffix uses the block-shifted masks from Sec. 5.1, follows the generation patterns in Table 4, and is detokenized into continuous actions. In VLM TC policies, action token cross-entropy updates the VLM, but the token

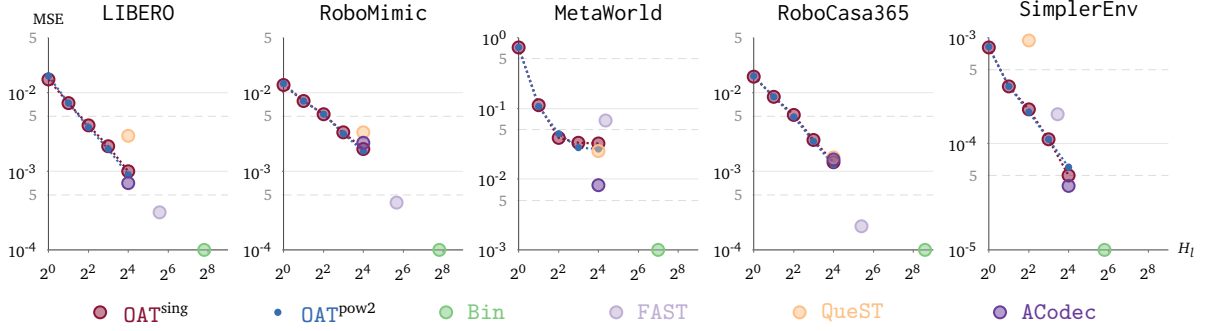


Figure 7: Rate-distortion curves for action tokenizers. Each panel plots raw reconstruction MSE against token budget on log-log axes; lower and further left is better. The **OAT** traces show mask-padded partial decodings under token-wise and power-of-two variants for $k \in \{1, 2, 4, 8, 16\}$, while Bin, FAST, QueST, and ACodec appear as fixed-budget operating points at their full token length, with FAST using its average BPE length. Near-zero Bin errors are drawn on the x-axis for visual consistency. Detailed token counts and MSE values are listed in Table 9.

Scheme	Simulation				Real-world		Avg. Rank
	LIBERO-Long	RoboMimic	MetaWorld	RoboCasa	P&P Ball	Stack Cups	
Bin	14.4	39.5	14.5	27.7	4/20	8/20	5.8
FAST	23.0	24.0	7.1	13.2	8/20	6/20	6.2
QueST	48.2	66.9	17.9	52.3	11/20	8/20	2.8
$\text{OAT}_1^{\text{sing}}$	11.7	50.8	11.3	47.7	7/20	3/20	6.0
$\text{OAT}_2^{\text{sing}}$	39.8	52.5	16.4	50.3	11/20	9/20	3.8
$\text{OAT}_4^{\text{sing}}$	46.4	65.3	19.5	51.7	13/20	12/20	2.5
$\text{OAT}_8^{\text{sing}}$	56.3	73.1	24.4	54.6	16/20	16/20	1.0

Table 5: Lightweight policy simulation and real-world results. Simulation entries are mean success rates in percent with a fixed Transformer policy; real-world entries are successful trials out of 20 independent rollouts. For this lightweight comparison, FAST uses strict decoding, so invalid FAST token sequences are rejected as described in Sec. 3. Avg. Rank is balanced over the four simulation benchmarks and two real-world tasks; lower is better.

branch is removed at inference. A flow-matching expert executes actions from detached layer-wise VLM K/V context, noisy actions, and flow-time embeddings; the flow loss updates only this expert. We use velocity flow-matching with 10 Euler steps.

6.3 Rate-Distortion of Action Tokens

Fig. 7 measures reconstruction error from truncated token prefixes. For token budget k , we retain $T_{1:k}$, fill the ungenerated suffix with mask tokens, decode the partial sequence into $\hat{a}^{(k)}$, and compute $\varepsilon(k) = \|a_{1:H_a} - \hat{a}^{(k)}\|_2^2$. This diagnostic quantifies how much action information each prefix budget preserves before the tokens are used as policy targets.

Within this rate-distortion view, **OAT** remains in the compact operating regime of learned tokenizers while preserving executable partial decodings. Both token-wise and power-of-two variants reduce reconstruction error smoothly with token budget. Exact token counts and MSEs (10^{-3}) are listed in Appendix E.

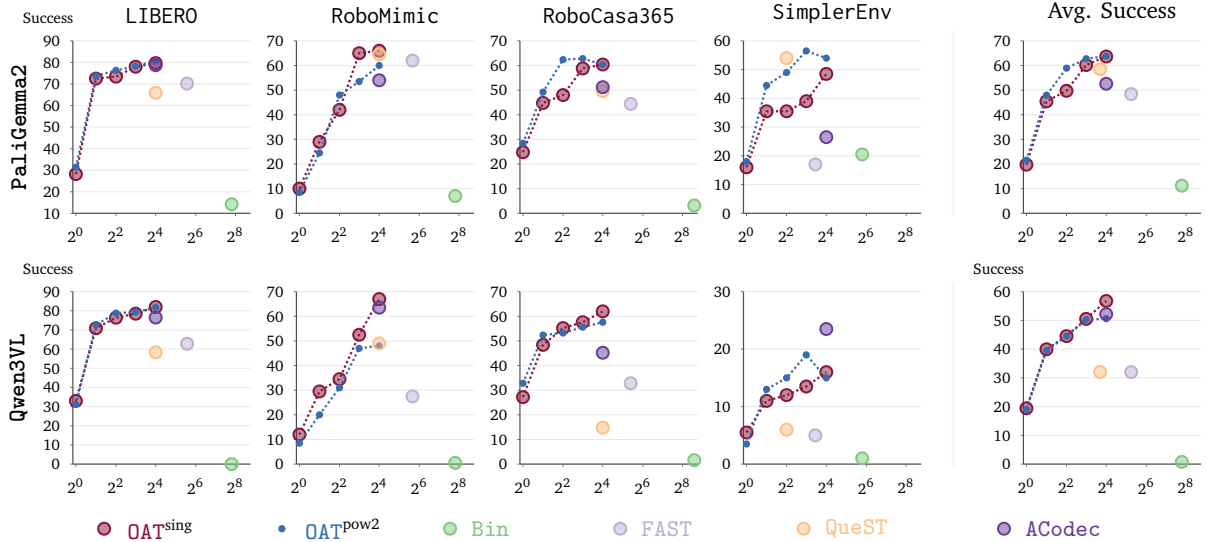


Figure 8: Closed-loop autoregressive VLM policy success rates. Each panel reports mean task success over 50 rollouts per task for one VLM backbone and benchmark group. The x-axis is token budget on a 2^t scale. Dotted curves trace **OAT** token budgets; fixed-budget baselines are plotted at their tokenizer lengths. Call counts are listed in Table 4. Rightmost panels report benchmark-balanced average success for each backbone. Numeric values are provided in Table 10.

6.4 Lightweight Policies in Simulation and Real-world Control

After the tokenizer diagnostics, Table 5 evaluates whether compact **OAT** prefixes improve closed-loop control. All rows use the same small Transformer policy, giving a fixed-backbone comparison of the action representation and generation pattern. The simulation suite covers LIBERO-Long, RoboMimic, MetaWorld, and RoboCasa; the same lightweight policy stack is then evaluated on the Pick-and-Place Ball and Stack Cups real-robot tasks shown in Fig. 6.

OAT improves lightweight policy performance as more tokens are decoded. The shortest budgets are executable but coarse, whereas **OAT**₈^{sing} gives the highest point estimate in every simulation and real-world group and the best average rank across benchmarks. The comparison with QueST is informative: both methods use compact learned latents, but only **OAT** trains ordered prefixes to place control-relevant action information early. The matched ordering ablation in Fig. 10 tests this factor directly. These lightweight results provide closed-loop evidence that **OAT** prefixes improve policy learning; the next section evaluates whether the same representation remains useful at VLM scale.

6.5 VLM-Scale Policy Studies

At VLM scale, we evaluate **OAT** under two roles for action tokens. In AR policies, the VLM predicts action tokens that are detokenized into actions. In TC policies, token losses supervise the VLM while a flow-matching expert executes actions.

6.5.1 Autoregressive VLM Policies

Fig. 8 shows that **OAT** remains effective as action tokens for VLM AR policies. For both VLM backbones, increasing the **OAT** token budget generally improves success. The best token-wise result is **OAT**₁₆^{sing}: 63.7 with PaliGemma2 and 56.8 with Qwen3VL.

BAR exposes the depth–accuracy tradeoff for the same ordered token family. With PaliGemma2 at $k = 16$, the power-of-two variant matches the token-wise variant (63.8 vs. 63.7) while using 5

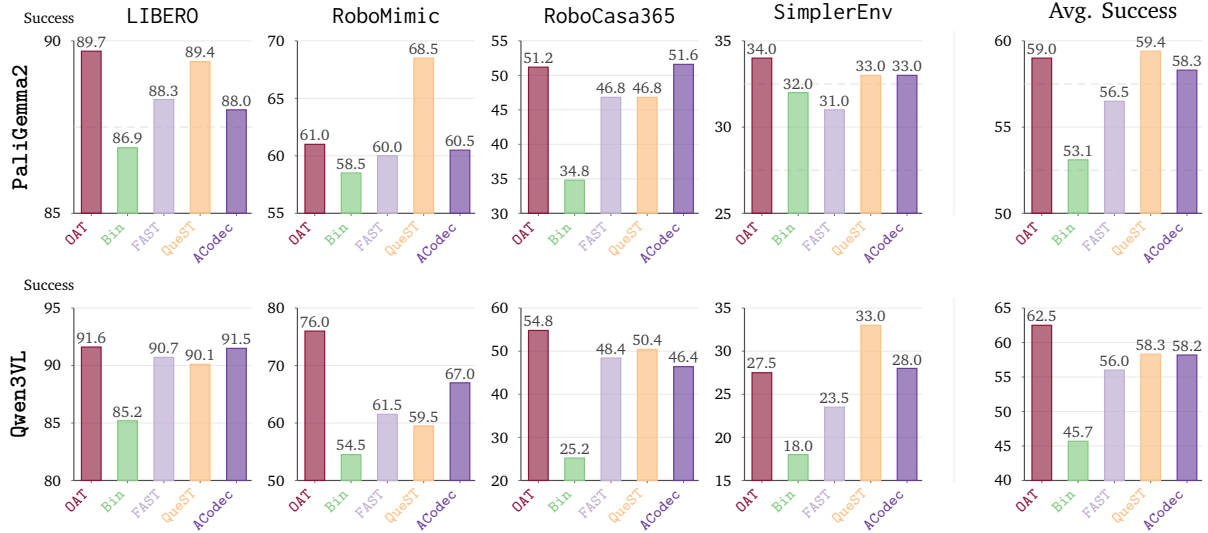


Figure 9: Closed-loop token co-training VLM policy success rates. Rows are VLM backbones trained with action token supervision and a stop-gradient boundary that blocks flow-matching expert losses from updating the VLM. Columns report mean task success over 50 evaluation episodes per task on LIBERO, RoboMimic, RoboCasa365, and SimplerEnv, plus the average with equal weight across the four benchmark panels. Within each row, bars compare the action token supervision used during training: **OAT**, **Bin**, **FAST**, **QueST**, and **ACodec**. At inference, these tokens are not decoded; the flow-matching expert produces actions from cached, detached VLM K/V context. Numeric labels give success in percent. Each panel uses its own vertical axis scale, shown by tick labels, so compare bar heights within each panel.

BAR stages instead of 16 token-wise calls. With Qwen3VL, token-wise conditioning is stronger at the largest budget (56.8 vs. 50.6). Full values are reported in [Appendix F](#).

Baseline comparisons further show that tokenizer design remains consequential at VLM scale. **Bin** reconstructs almost exactly in [Table 9](#), yet its long action suffix gives poor average success with both VLM backbones. **ACodec** makes the opposite design choice from token-wise AR by predicting all action tokens in one policy call, but its performance varies across benchmarks and backbones. These contrasts indicate that useful action tokens must be compact and decodable while remaining learnable by the policy interface.

6.5.2 Token co-training VLM Policies

[Fig. 9](#) shows that tokenizer choice remains consequential when tokens are used only for supervision. Under VLM TC supervision, **OAT** reaches 59.0 average success with PaliGemma2, effectively tied with **QueST** and **ACodec** while outperforming **Bin** and **FAST** on average. It gives the top success on LIBERO and SimplerEnv, while **QueST** is stronger on RoboMimic (68.5 vs. 61.0). With Qwen3VL, **OAT** gives the highest average success at 62.5, with clear gains on RoboMimic and RoboCasa365. The main exception is SimplerEnv, where **QueST** reaches 33.0 versus 27.5 for **OAT**. Thus tokenizer design matters even when tokens supervise the VLM instead of defining the executed action, but the best tokenizer can depend on the backbone and benchmark.

6.6 Ablation and Analysis

Ablations examine the main design choices behind **OAT**: token ordering, action and token horizons, codebook capacity, and schedule-matched grouped generation. Unless otherwise specified, these studies use the lightweight Transformer setting, so each comparison keeps the policy backbone fixed and changes only the action representation.

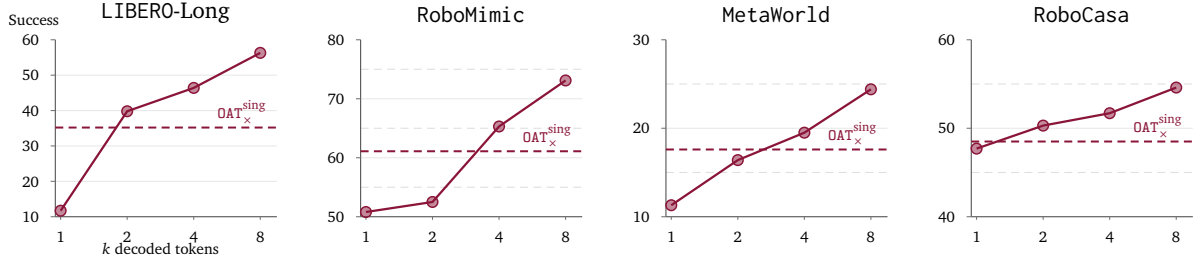


Figure 10: Token ordering ablation. Each panel reports one benchmark in the lightweight setting, with mean success over 50 rollouts per task when decoding the first k OAT^{sing} tokens. Solid curves show ordered OAT^{sing} budgets; dashed lines show $\text{OAT}_x^{\text{sing}}$, which removes nested dropout during tokenizer training while keeping the tokenizer architecture and policy interface fixed.

$H_l \backslash H_a$	8	16	32	64
1	38.3	26.0	6.4	2.8
2	50.2	45.9	26.6	12.9
4	68.1	54.8	37.7	13.1
8	63.0	57.1	56.3	19.4

(a) Half-horizon execution.

$H_l \backslash H_a$	8	16	32	64
1	28.7	26.0	7.6	0.8
2	37.1	45.9	28.4	17.5
4	64.6	54.8	42.9	18.3
8	54.5	57.1	62.5	27.3

(b) Fixed 8-action execution.

Figure 11: Action and token horizons. $\text{OAT}_{H_l}^{\text{sing}}$ success on LIBERO-Long with a fixed Transformer policy as action horizon H_a and the latent token horizon H_l varies. (a) queries again after executing $\frac{1}{2}H_a$ actions; (b) always executes 8 actions, isolating execution frequency. The panels expose compression and replanning tradeoffs. Values are success over 50 rollouts per task; darker cells are better.

FSQ levels	$ \mathcal{V} $	LIBERO
[8, 6, 5]	240	29.2
[8, 8, 8]	512	53.5
[8, 5, 5, 5]	1000	56.3
[8, 8, 6, 5]	1920	54.6
[7, 5, 5, 5, 5]	4375	46.9

Table 6: Codebook capacity scaling. OAT^{sing} success on LIBERO-Long with fixed Transformer ($H_a = 32$, $H_l = 8$) as FSQ levels vary [53]. Moderate vocabularies work best: too few codes can restrict the representation, while too many can make token targets harder to learn.

6.6.1 Does Token Ordering Improve Policy Performance?

Fig. 10 evaluates the effect of token ordering. $\text{OAT}_x^{\text{sing}}$ removes nested dropout, so short prefixes are no longer trained to reconstruct the action chunk. This separates the ordering objective from learnable registers and compact latent capacity.

Removing ordering consistently degrades lightweight policy success. $\text{OAT}_x^{\text{sing}}$ still uses the full latent horizon, so it is often stronger than the shortest OAT^{sing} budgets, but it remains well below $\text{OAT}_8^{\text{sing}}$ and is often closer to $\text{OAT}_2^{\text{sing}}$ or $\text{OAT}_4^{\text{sing}}$. This supports the claim that compact latent tokens alone are insufficient for strong policies. Ordering is an important factor: next-token prediction benefits when high-impact action structure appears early and residual detail later.

6.6.2 How Do Action and Token Horizons Trade Off?

Fig. 11 studies two central factors in chunk-level action tokenization: the predicted action horizon H_a and the latent token horizon H_l . Larger H_a provides more future context to the policy, but also requires the tokenizer to compress a longer continuous trajectory. Larger H_l provides more register slots, but increases the action token suffix that the policy must model. We train models for $H_a \in \{8, 16, 32, 64\}$ and $H_l \in \{1, 2, 4, 8\}$ on LIBERO-Long and evaluate two execution protocols: execution after half the action horizon, which matches the protocol used elsewhere, and fixed 8-action execution, which holds execution frequency constant.

Executing half the action horizon exposes the compression side of the tradeoff. For a fixed H_l ,

Scheme	Tokenizer	Generation	Calls	LIBERO
$\text{OAT}_{16}^{\text{sing}}$	token-wise	token-wise AR	16	79.7
$\text{OAT}_{16}^{\text{sing}}$ + post-hoc BAR	token-wise	power-of-two BAR	5	66.3
$\text{OAT}_{16}^{\text{pow2}}$	power-of-two	power-of-two BAR	5	80.8

Table 7: Schedule-matched OAT training on LIBERO. Mean success under PaliGemma2. Post-hoc BAR changes generation only; $\text{OAT}_{16}^{\text{pow2}}$ uses matched tokenizer training.

success generally drops as H_a grows because the same number of tokens must represent a longer future chunk. Increasing H_l mitigates this drop, indicating that additional register slots are needed to preserve fine temporal structure. This supports using a larger latent horizon such as $H_l = 8$, while the action horizon must also account for execution frequency.

The fixed 8-action protocol separates prediction horizon from execution frequency. For a fixed H_l , a longer H_a can initially help because the policy predicts further into the future while executing the same number of actions per query. However, very long horizons again become difficult to compress, especially for $H_l \in \{1, 2\}$. In this setting, $H_a = 32$ with $H_l = 8$ is a strong compromise between lookahead and compression. The two heatmaps therefore point to the same design rule: action chunking and token capacity should be chosen jointly.

6.6.3 How Does Codebook Capacity Affect Policy Success?

Table 6 varies the FSQ levels while keeping the rest of the tokenizer fixed, isolating discrete vocabulary capacity from the number of latent tokens. The trend is non-monotonic. Success improves as the vocabulary increases from 240 to roughly 1000–2000 codes, consistent with the intuition that a small codebook is restrictive. Beyond that range, performance drops even though the tokenizer has more discrete capacity. One plausible explanation is that larger vocabularies spread supervision over more discrete targets, so the policy observes fewer examples per code. This reinforces the broader point from Sec. 3: effective action tokens must reconstruct actions and remain learnable policy targets.

6.6.4 Does Grouped Generation Require Schedule-Matched OAT Training?

The final ablation tests whether OAT can be regrouped at inference without matching tokenizer training to the intended generation schedule. We keep the pretrained token-wise OAT tokenizer fixed ($\text{OAT}_{16}^{\text{sing}}$), apply power-of-two grouped generation post hoc, and compare it with a tokenizer trained for matching power-of-two prefixes ($\text{OAT}_{16}^{\text{pow2}}$).

Table 7 separates faster generation from tokenizer compatibility. For $\text{OAT}_{16}^{\text{sing}}$, switching only the generation pattern reduces the number of calls from 16 to 5, but success drops from 79.7 to 66.3. $\text{OAT}_{16}^{\text{pow2}}$ reaches 80.8 with the same call count. Grouped generation therefore works best when OAT training uses the same budget structure that will be used at inference.

7 Related Work

We group related work around action targets and generation procedures: action chunking, VLA action interfaces, action tokenization, ordered representations, and partially parallel generation.

7.1 Action Chunking and Continuous Control

Action chunking is now a standard interface for visuomotor policies because it predicts temporally coherent control segments and amortizes inference across multiple environment steps (Zhao et al.,

2023; Zhang et al., 2025). Diffusion and flow-matching policies provide strong continuous decoders for high-frequency control (Chi et al., 2025; Black et al., 2025), and multitask diffusion systems extend this interface across task families, sensing modalities, and symbolic-continuous planning settings (Liu et al., 2026; Chen et al., 2025; Høeg et al., 2026; Liu et al., 2026). These methods establish the action chunk as an effective control unit, but usually leave the chunk in continuous space. Our work addresses the complementary discrete setting: when a chunk is exposed as a token sequence, what structure makes those tokens compact, decodable, and learnable by an AR policy?

7.2 Vision-Language-Action Models and Discrete Action Interfaces

Large robot policies increasingly condition on language and often reuse VLM backbones for embodied control (Zitkovich et al., 2023; Driess et al., 2023; Ghosh et al., 2024; Kim et al., 2024; Li et al., 2024; Qu et al., 2025; Wen et al., 2025; Black et al., 2025; NVIDIA et al., 2025). Large-scale datasets and generalist policy efforts make this interface practical across heterogeneous tasks and embodiments (O’Neill et al., 2024; Walke et al., 2023; Khazatsky et al., 2024; Bousmalis et al., 2024). For VLA models that autoregressively emit action tokens, the tokenizer determines the output vocabulary, sequence length, action validity, and difficulty of the next-token prediction problem. Recent studies and surveys therefore treat action tokenization as a central VLA design axis (Zhong et al., 2025; Vuong et al., 2025; Wang et al., 2025). Discrete diffusion VLA decoders make a related choice by keeping actions in a discrete token space while replacing fixed left-to-right decoding with iterative parallel refinement (Liang et al., 2025).

TC-style VLA systems, sometimes referred to as knowledge insulation (KI) in other literature, address a different problem: robot adaptation should not destroy pretrained VLM knowledge. In this setting, discrete action token losses update the VLM, while a diffusion or flow-matching expert consumes detached VLM K/V context and executes continuous actions (Black et al., 2025; Driess et al., 2025; Intelligence et al., 2026; Fang et al., 2026). Large-scale data-mixture studies similarly find that appropriate vision-language and cross-embodiment data can restore VLM understanding degraded by robot-only training (Lin et al., 2026). These systems motivate discrete action supervision, but they do not settle which action token properties matter when tokens train an AR policy or serve as TC supervision while a continuous expert executes actions.

7.3 Action Tokenizers and Latent Actions

Existing action tokenizers trade off compression, guaranteed decoding, and the difficulty of policy prediction. Per-dimension Bin is widely used in AR robot systems (Brohan et al., 2023; Zitkovich et al., 2023; Kim et al., 2024); it is simple and totally decodable, and coordinates can be grouped by action step for block-wise prediction, but sequence length grows with action dimension and chunk horizon. FAST compresses chunks with frequency-domain structure and BPE (Pertsch et al., 2025), giving a low-to-high-frequency order while introducing variable-length decoding issues. Learned latent tokenizers compress actions with neural encoders and discrete bottlenecks, including skill or latent action abstractions (Mete et al., 2024; Lee et al., 2024; Ye et al., 2025) and vector-quantized tokenizers for VLA policies (van den Oord et al., 2017; Mentzer et al., 2024; Wang et al., 2025; Dong et al., 2026). Other work uses token surrogates for actions in in-context imitation learning and robotic sequence modeling (Palo and Johns, 2024; Fu et al., 2025; Bonatti et al., 2022). These methods establish that action tokens can serve as policy targets, but leave open which token properties make downstream policy learning reliable.

7.4 Ordered and Progressive Tokenization

Ordered representations provide an inductive bias for models that consume or generate partial codes. Nested dropout and Matryoshka-style objectives train representations that remain informative at multiple budgets (Rippel et al., 2014; Kusupati et al., 2022; Cai et al., 2025; Bachmann et al., 2025). Related image and sequence models demonstrate that code design and autoregressive factorization choices can change the modeling problem seen by a downstream generator (Kolesnikov et al., 2022; Wen et al., 2025; Khemakhem et al., 2021; Im et al., 2025). This connects to a broader perspective on latent-space generation in which representations should be chosen not only for reconstruction quality, but also for downstream predictability (Tschannen et al., 2018; Dieleman, 2025; Zhao et al., 2025; Kim et al., 2025). Robot action tokens add a constraint specific to control: prefixes used for control should decode to action chunks, not only embeddings.

7.5 Partially Parallel Generation

Partially parallel generation reduces the latency of strictly AR decoding by predicting, verifying, or refining multiple tokens per stage. Block-wise parallel decoding, speculative decoding, masked prediction, and non-autoregressive refinement instantiate this idea in language and sequence models (Stern et al., 2018; Leviathan et al., 2023; Ghazvininejad et al., 2019; Lee et al., 2018). Recent VLA tokenizers also target latency and prediction difficulty in action generation (Liu et al., 2026; Dong et al., 2026), while block diffusion uses block-level denoising to interpolate between autoregressive and parallel generation (Arriola et al., 2025). We formulate BAR as the action token counterpart of this line, with prior fixed-size block action token prediction as one point in this family.

8 Conclusion and Limitations

This paper studied action tokenization as a policy interface for visuomotor policy learning. We formalized three desiderata: high compression, total decodability, and ordered token structure. We then introduced **OAT**, a learned tokenizer whose mask-padded prefixes decode to executable action chunks. Early tokens capture coarse control, while later tokens refine residual detail, allowing the same token structure to serve either as AR policy outputs or as token supervision under TC.

Across tokenizer diagnostics, lightweight control, VLM-scale AR and TC policies, and ablations, the results show that **OAT** is a strong action token interface. For AR policies, **OAT** improves closed-loop control; BAR further formalizes token-wise, block-wise, one-shot, and power-of-two schedules, making the tradeoff between policy call depth and block prediction difficulty explicit. Under TC, tokenizer choice remains consequential even when action tokens are not decoded at inference, indicating that ordered token supervision can shape VLM context in useful ways.

The study is intentionally scoped to isolate tokenizer effects. We evaluate a fixed set of manipulation benchmarks, policy backbones, action horizons, and token budgets; broader embodiments, longer-horizon tasks, and larger real-world mixtures remain important tests of the same design principles. We also keep the flow-matching expert in TC policies fixed while varying tokenizers, leaving the joint design of expert architecture and token supervision for future work.

A natural next step is adaptive computation. Current policies choose token or block budgets before inference, but **OAT** prefixes are executable at every trained budget and BAR makes the cost of additional generated blocks explicit. Future policies could decide online when another token or block is worth the policy call, using token entropy, reconstruction uncertainty, or downstream value estimates (Graves, 2016; Banino et al., 2021; Dehghani et al., 2019; Elbayad et al., 2020). This would reserve deeper AR refinement for precise or high-risk moments while keeping simple control decisions compact.

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Contents

1	Introduction	2
2	Preliminaries	3
3	Action Tokenization as a Policy Interface	4
3.1	Tokenizer Desiderata	4
3.2	Where Existing Tokenizers Fall Short	5
4	OAT: Ordered Action Tokenization	6
4.1	Tokenization $\mathcal{T}$ and Detokenization $\mathcal{T}^{-1}$	6
4.2	Ordered Prefix Training for Progressive Tokens	7
4.3	Progressive Information Allocation	7
4.4	Token-Wise and Power-of-Two Variants	8
5	OAT for Visuomotor Policies	9
5.1	Block-wise Autoregressive OAT Generation	9
5.2	Token Co-Training with OAT	10
6	Experiments	11
6.1	Evaluation Regimes and Benchmarks	11
6.2	Experimental Protocol and Implementation	12
6.3	Rate-Distortion of Action Tokens	14
6.4	Lightweight Policies in Simulation and Real-world Control	15
6.5	VLM-Scale Policy Studies	15
6.5.1	Autoregressive VLM Policies	15
6.5.2	Token co-training VLM Policies	16
6.6	Ablation and Analysis	16
6.6.1	Does Token Ordering Improve Policy Performance?	17
6.6.2	How Do Action and Token Horizons Trade Off?	17
6.6.3	How Does Codebook Capacity Affect Policy Success?	18
6.6.4	Does Grouped Generation Require Schedule-Matched OAT Training?	18
7	Related Work	18
7.1	Action Chunking and Continuous Control	18
7.2	Vision-Language-Action Models and Discrete Action Interfaces	19
7.3	Action Tokenizers and Latent Actions	19
7.4	Ordered and Progressive Tokenization	20
7.5	Partially Parallel Generation	20
8	Conclusion and Limitations	20
A	Block-Wise Autoregressive Training and Inference	35
A.1	Block Patterns	35
A.2	Block-Shifted Teacher Forcing	36
A.3	Block-Wise Inference	36
A.4	Matching Tokenizer Training to Block-Wise Generation	36
B	Token Co-Training for Vision-Language-Action Control	38

C	Optimization Protocols	40
D	Action Tokenizer Baselines and Their Tradeoffs	41
D.1	Per-Dimension Binning Is Total but Long	41
D.2	Frequency-Domain Tokens Are Ordered but Not Total	41
D.3	Learned Latents Are Compact but Not Necessarily Predictable	42
E	Rate–Distortion Across Action Token Budgets	43
F	Autoregressive Action Generation with Vision-Language Models	44

A Block-Wise Autoregressive Training and Inference

This appendix completes the specification of block-wise autoregression (BAR) introduced in [Sec. 5.1](#) and its integration with [OAT](#). It details block patterns, block-shifted teacher forcing, inference, and tokenizer compatibility. Within autoregressive (AR) generation, BAR covers token-wise AR, one-shot parallel decoding ([Dong et al., 2026](#)), prior fixed-size block prediction ([Liu et al., 2026](#); [Dong et al., 2026](#)), and intermediate schedules, thereby exposing the tradeoff between sequential policy depth and within-block prediction difficulty. Related depth-reduction methods include block-wise parallel decoding, masked prediction, and non-autoregressive generation ([Stern et al., 2018](#); [Ghazvininejad et al., 2019](#); [Lee et al., 2018](#)).

A.1 Block Patterns

For a fixed-length action token sequence $T_{1:H_l}$, let $\mathbf{b} = (b_0, b_1, \dots, b_S)$ denote the endpoint list, with $0 = b_0 < b_1 < \dots < b_S = H_l$. At stage s , BAR generates the block $G_s = T_{b_{s-1}+1:b_s}$, whose size is

$$g_s = |G_s| = b_s - b_{s-1}.$$

After this stage, the realized prefix is $T_{1:b_s}$. For indexing, we use the empty-prefix convention $G_0 = T_{1:0} = \emptyset$ and set $g_0 = 0$. The endpoint list therefore determines both the number of sequential policy calls S and the number of action tokens predicted in parallel at each stage.

As illustrated in [Fig. 5](#), the BAR family ranges from token-wise autoregression to one-shot parallel decoding, with fixed-size and variable-size blocks between those endpoints. This formulation is consistent with recent evidence that token ordering and decoding order can strongly affect partially parallel generative models ([Kim et al., 2025](#)).

For the shifted-slot implementation below, we restrict BAR schedules to nondecreasing generated block sizes,

$$g_1 \leq g_2 \leq \dots \leq g_S.$$

Early stages keep small blocks, so early positions receive more serial conditioning; later stages save policy calls by predicting larger blocks. In particular, we use the positive endpoints

$$(b_1, b_2, \dots, b_S) = (1, 2, 4, 8, 16, \dots, 2^{S-1}).$$

These endpoints induce the block sizes

$$(g_1, g_2, \dots, g_S) = (1, 1, 2, 4, 8, \dots, 2^{S-2}).$$

For $H_l = 2^{S-1}$, this schedule reduces the sequential policy depth from $O(H_l)$ to $O(\log H_l)$.

Power-of-two budgets use the fewest stages under a balanced growth constraint. Starting from $b_1 = 1$, require each later generated block to be no larger than the realized prefix. For $s \geq 2$,

$$\begin{aligned} g_s &= b_s - b_{s-1} \leq b_{s-1}, \\ b_s &= b_{s-1} + g_s \leq 2b_{s-1}. \end{aligned}$$

It follows that S stages reach at most $b_S \leq 2^{S-1}$ tokens. Reaching a length- K prefix therefore requires at least $1 + \lceil \log_2 K \rceil$ stages. When K is a power of two, doubling the prefix length at each stage meets this bound exactly.

A.2 Block-Shifted Teacher Forcing

BAR trains each generation stage with the same shifted context structure used at inference. For stage s , define the block-shifted input sequence

$$X^{(s)} = T_{1:b_{s-1}} \oplus \langle \text{MASK} \rangle^{g_s - g_{s-1}}.$$

The final g_s slots of $X^{(s)}$ are the logit-read slots. When $s > 1$, these slots contain the previous block context followed by padding masks:

$$G_{s-1} \oplus \langle \text{MASK} \rangle^{g_s - g_{s-1}}.$$

Nondecreasing block sizes ensure that this shifted window can carry the previous block while adding only new mask slots as the block width grows. The policy reads logits from these slots and supervises them against the current block G_s . Let π denote the policy, o its observation context, and $p_{\pi,j}^{(s)}(\cdot | X^{(s)}, o)$ denote the categorical distribution read from the j -th final logit-read slot. The loss is

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{BAR}} = - \sum_{s=1}^S \sum_{j=1}^{g_s} \log p_{\pi,j}^{(s)}(T_{b_{s-1}+j} | X^{(s)}, o).$$

This block-shifted objective produces all g_s logits in one policy forward pass while blocking access to ground-truth tokens from the current block. Each logit-read slot sees only realized prefix tokens or masks and is supervised against its target token in G_s ; a block-causal attention mask still allows mask-slot states to interact.

A.3 Block-Wise Inference

Inference mirrors the same block structure and shifted slots. Stage 1 feeds g_1 masks and predicts $\hat{G}_1$. For $s > 1$, the policy uses

$$\hat{X}^{(s)} = \hat{T}_{1:b_{s-1}} \oplus \langle \text{MASK} \rangle^{g_s - g_{s-1}},$$

whose final g_s logit-read slots are

$$\hat{G}_{s-1} \oplus \langle \text{MASK} \rangle^{g_s - g_{s-1}}.$$

The previous block symbols in these slots are shifted context, not newly appended tokens. The policy reads the g_s predictions from the final slots and appends only the predicted block $\hat{G}_s$ to the prefix. After the final stage, the complete action token sequence is

$$\hat{T}_{1:H_l} = \hat{G}_1 \oplus \hat{G}_2 \oplus \dots \oplus \hat{G}_S.$$

The completed sequence can be detokenized by any tokenizer that supports full-sequence decoding. If the tokenizer supports partial decoding, then after stage s the prefix $\hat{T}_{1:b_s}$ can also be decoded as a lower-budget action chunk after s policy calls.

A.4 Matching Tokenizer Training to Block-Wise Generation

OAT training and BAR generation are aligned by using the same endpoint list $\mathbf{b}$. During tokenizer training, each positive endpoint b_s , for $s \in \{1, \dots, S\}$, is a reconstruction budget, and the endpoints partition the tokens into groups $G_s = T_{b_{s-1}+1:b_s}$. The register self-attention mask allows each register to attend to earlier groups while preventing direct attention to other registers introduced within the same group. During policy inference, BAR treats the corresponding group as the block generated at stage s . At that stage, the policy predicts $\hat{G}_s$ in one forward pass from the observation and the

block-shifted input $\widehat{X}^{(s)}$ defined above, which contains the generated prefix and any required mask slots but no tokens from $\widehat{G}_s$.

This alignment determines the generation schedule for each **OAT** variant used in our experiments. For **OAT**^{sing}, $b_s = s$, so generating a length- K prefix requires K sequential policy calls. For **OAT**^{pow2} with full token horizon $H_l = 16$, the endpoints $(1, 2, 4, 8, 16)$ induce block sizes $(1, 1, 2, 4, 8)$, requiring five calls to generate the complete token sequence. At each matched endpoint b_s , the generated prefix $\widehat{T}_{1:b_s}$ can be suffix-padded to length H_l with the learned mask tokens and passed to the decoder, matching the masked-prefix input form used during tokenizer training. Inference can therefore stop at any endpoint shared by tokenizer training and policy generation and decode the current prefix, or continue to a later endpoint and decode an action chunk from a larger token budget, as summarized in [Algo. 2](#).

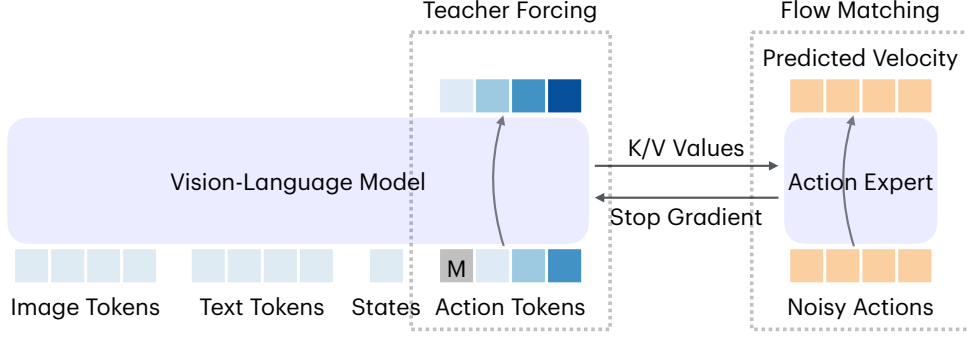


Figure 12: TC computation graph. The VLM predicts targets produced by a frozen **OAT** tokenizer under teacher forcing, and the resulting token loss trains the VLM. Gray “M” denotes the leading mask used to predict the first target. In parallel, the flow-matching expert receives noisy actions and a detached K/V cache from the image, language, and state prefill; the cache excludes the teacher-forced action token positions. At inference, the token branch is omitted and the expert generates a continuous action chunk from the cached context.

B Token Co-Training for Vision-Language-Action Control

This appendix expands the token co-training (TC) interface in [Sec. 5.2](#) for vision-language-action (VLA) control. TC combines token supervision for the vision-language model (VLM) with a continuous flow-matching expert. Continuous action decoders are effective for control ([Chi et al., 2025](#); [Black et al., 2025](#)), but allowing the corresponding continuous action loss to update a pretrained VLM can degrade its knowledge ([Driess et al., 2025](#)). The stop-gradient boundary in [Eq. \(5.1\)](#) isolates the VLM from the flow loss while preserving its context as input to the expert ([Driess et al., 2025](#)). [Fig. 12](#) summarizes the resulting computation graph.

Teacher-forced token supervision. Let c denote the image, language, and robot state context. For a continuous action chunk $a_{1:H_a}$, the frozen tokenizer supplies targets $T_{1:H_t} = \mathcal{T}(a_{1:H_a})$. The token loss in [Eq. \(5.1\)](#) is the cross-entropy for predicting each T_i from c and the shifted action token prefix $\langle \text{MASK} \rangle, T_{1:i-1}$. The leading mask supplies the prediction slot for T_1 , and this branch updates the VLM through action token prediction.

Detached context and flow matching. The expert receives the layer-wise key/value (K/V) cache $KV_{\text{VLM}}(c)$ from the image, language, and state prefill. This cache excludes K/V values from the teacher-forced action token positions ([Dong et al., 2026](#)). State and language therefore condition the expert through the detached cache rather than as separate raw inputs. Given a normalized action chunk a , Gaussian noise ϵ , and flow time τ , we use

$$\begin{aligned} a_\tau &= \tau\epsilon + (1 - \tau)a, \\ v &= \epsilon - a. \end{aligned}$$

Thus the noised action $\tilde{a}_{1:H_a}^\tau$ in [Eq. \(5.1\)](#) is a_τ . The expert takes the detached K/V cache, a_τ , a flow-time embedding, and an action padding mask as inputs. Its flow loss is the mean squared error (MSE) between the predicted velocity and v . We use all VLM layers by default, weight both token and flow losses by 1.0, and apply stop-gradient only at the VLM context passed to the expert.

Inference. For each action chunk, the VLM is prefilled once on c and its logits are discarded. Starting from Gaussian noise at $\tau = 1$, the flow-matching expert uses the cached VLM context to

integrate the learned velocity backward to $\tau = 0$ with 10 uniform Euler steps. The action token branch is absent, so executed actions come from the expert rather than detokenization.

In principle, any tokenizer that maps continuous action chunks to discrete symbols can provide TC targets. Prior systems often use Frequency-space Action Sequence Tokenization (FAST) (Driess et al., 2025; Black et al., 2025; Intelligence et al., 2026; Pertsch et al., 2025). Within each backbone, our comparison holds the VLM, action expert, cache interface, flow objective, loss weights, and inference solver fixed; only the tokenizer and resulting supervision targets change.

C Optimization Protocols

This appendix reports the implementation details needed to interpret the policy comparisons in [Sec. 6](#). Because the main experiments vary action token design while keeping the policy recipe fixed within each family, the relevant reproducibility details are the optimization recipes summarized below. Full launch-level configuration is provided in the released code.

Optimization protocols across model families. [Table 8](#) lists the optimization recipe used by each model family. Learned latent tokenizers use one recipe; all discrete autoregressive (AR) policies, including block-wise autoregression (BAR) patterns, use a single policy optimization recipe independent of generation pattern; and token co-training (TC) policies use a separate recipe for their joint token and flow objective. This presentation keeps the appendix focused on comparability: within a family, differences in closed-loop success should be read against a fixed optimizer, learning rate schedule, warmup, weight decay, gradient clipping, and batch size. In [Table 8](#), Opt., LR, sched., Min, WD, and Clip denote optimizer, learning rate, schedule, minimum, weight decay, and gradient clipping norm, respectively.

Component	Opt.	LR	Batch	LR sched.	Warmup	Min LR ratio	WD	Clip
Latent tokenizers	AdamW	5e-5	512	constant	200	–	0	1.0
AR policies	AdamW	1e-4	16	cosine	500	0.1	1e-6	1.0
TC policies	AdamW	5e-5	32	constant	10k	–	1e-6	1.0

Table 8: Training recipes. Optimization settings for learned latent tokenizers, AR policies, and TC policies. The AR row covers token-wise, fixed-size, one-shot, and variable block patterns. Opt. is the optimizer, LR sched. is the learning rate schedule, WD is weight decay, and clip is the gradient clipping norm.

D Action Tokenizer Baselines and Their Tradeoffs

D.1 Per-Dimension Binning Is Total but Long

Per-dimension Bin is the standard total decoding baseline for autoregressive (AR) robot policies (Brohan et al., 2023; Zitkovich et al., 2023; Kim et al., 2024). Each scalar action coordinate is normalized to a fixed range, commonly $[-1, 1]$, divided into N uniform bins, and mapped to the corresponding bin index. For an action chunk of shape $H_a \times D_a$, Bin produces the serialization

$$\mathcal{T}(a_{1:H_a}) = [T_{1,1}, \dots, T_{1,D_a}, T_{2,1}, \dots, T_{H_a,D_a}].$$

Each coordinate token satisfies $T_{i,j} \in [N]$. If every scalar is emitted as its own token, the resulting token horizon is $H_l = H_a D_a$.

Bin is reliable because its detokenizer is simple and total. Every bin index maps back to a scalar action value, so every sampled token sequence of the expected length maps to an action chunk. It also has near-perfect reconstruction as the number of bins grows, up to quantization error. Because the D_a coordinates at one time step can be predicted jointly, Bin is compatible with simple block-wise generation.

The drawback is rate and ordering. Common action chunks can require hundreds of tokens, increasing training cost and leaving at least H_a sequential prediction steps under the natural block pattern. The token order is also a manual serialization over dimensions and time: a prefix may contain a few coordinates of the first action step while saying nothing about the rest of the trajectory. Thus Bin is reliable as a decoder and supports coordinate blocks, but remains poor as a compact, predictable action representation: it satisfies P2 and simple block-wise generation, but fails to satisfy P1 and P3. The next natural attempt is to compress action chunks while preserving a structured order.

D.2 Frequency-Domain Tokens Are Ordered but Not Total

Frequency-domain tokenizers address the rate and ordering weaknesses of per-dimension binning by representing action trajectories through spectral coefficients (Cooley and Tukey, 1965). Frequency-space Action Sequence Tokenization (FAST) is one representative example: it applies the discrete cosine transform (DCT), quantizes the resulting spectral coefficients, and then applies byte-pair encoding (BPE) (Ahmed et al., 1974; Gage, 1994; Sennrich et al., 2016; Pertsch et al., 2025). The resulting order is compatible with AR policies because low-frequency components appear before high-frequency components. Early tokens tend to describe coarse motion structure, while later tokens encode higher-frequency detail. This gives FAST a form of AR-friendly ordering and high information density.

The limitation is structural decodability. A robot action chunk requires a fixed coefficient topology before it can be reshaped and transformed back into $H_a \times D_a$ control. After deterministic pruning, quantization, or flattening, the detokenizer expects a coefficient stream of fixed length N , and the positions in this stream are not interchangeable: each index corresponds to a particular frequency basis, temporal component, and action dimension.

BPE breaks this fixed-topology assumption because tokens expand to variable-length coefficient sequences. Let $e(T_i)$ be the coefficient subsequence obtained by expanding token T_i . For a generated sequence $T_{1:L}$, the recovered coefficient stream has length

$$|e(T_1) \oplus e(T_2) \oplus \dots \oplus e(T_L)| = \sum_{i=1}^L |e(T_i)|.$$

Valid decoding requires this length to equal N . Equivalently, the natural domain of the FAST detokenizer is

$$\mathcal{D}_{\text{FAST}} = \{T_{1:L} : \sum_{i=1}^L |e(T_i)| = N\},$$

which is a strict subset of the token sequences an AR policy can emit. A next-token policy is not inherently constrained to stay inside $\mathcal{D}_{\text{FAST}}$, so a generated sequence can expand to too few or too many coefficients. In that case, the inverse reshape and inverse frequency transform are mathematically undefined.

This creates a mismatch with fixed-position policy interfaces. Padding or truncation can keep the length valid, but later symbols occupy shifted coefficient slots. Rejection or constrained decoding instead changes what the policy may sample. Thus FAST is compact and ordered, but not total over unconstrained policy outputs. Its variable-length expansion also destabilizes fixed token budgets and block-wise autoregression (BAR) schedules, motivating learned latents with a fixed token horizon and a decoder defined over the full latent space.

D.3 Learned Latents Are Compact but Not Necessarily Predictable

Learned latent tokenizers address compression by learning a neural bottleneck for action chunks. Methods such as Quantized Skill Transformer (QueST) and ActionCodec (ACodec) map an action chunk into a latent sequence of shape $H_l \times D_l$, quantize that latent representation with vector quantization or finite scalar quantization (FSQ), and decode the quantized latents back into continuous actions (Lee et al., 2024; van den Oord et al., 2017; Mentzer et al., 2024; Mete et al., 2024; Wang et al., 2025; Dong et al., 2026). The latent horizon H_l and latent dimension D_l are hyperparameters, often chosen to be much smaller than the raw action dimension $H_a D_a$. For example, an action chunk with horizon $H_a = 32$ can be represented by a latent sequence with $H_l = 8$ tokens.

These tokenizers are attractive from a rate–distortion viewpoint. They can be much more compact than Bin, and their learned decoders are total over the discrete latent space: any valid code index at each latent position can be embedded and decoded into a continuous action chunk. This satisfies P1 and P2 under the policy’s supported token vocabulary. However, compactness and total decodability do not by themselves make the tokens learnable policy targets (Ramanujan et al., 2025). For sequential latent tokenizers such as QueST, a latent sequence optimized mainly for end-point reconstruction need not put important motion information early. The policy may then have to predict latent indices in an order that was not designed for next-token learning.

ACodec provides the prior fixed-size block prediction baseline in our comparison. Its latent groups are designed for joint prediction and joint decoding, so the policy emits a fixed block of action tokens per generation step (Dong et al., 2026). This reduces serial policy depth without exposing an AR-friendly prefix order. In our taxonomy, the tradeoff is block modeling difficulty: the policy must infer the tokens in each fixed block together. The remaining gap is an ordered latent code that stays compact and total while giving next-token prediction a more learnable conditional structure.

E Rate–Distortion Across Action Token Budgets

Table 9 gives the numeric values behind the rate–distortion curves in Fig. 7. Full-budget baselines appear as one operating point per benchmark and include per-dimension Bin, Frequency-space Action Sequence Tokenization (FAST), Quantized Skill Transformer (QueST), and ActionCodec (ACodec). OAT reports partial decodings at $k \in \{1, 2, 4, 8, 16\}$ under token-wise and power-of-two variants. For FAST, the token count is the average byte-pair encoding (BPE) length. The table reports the number of tokens (#Tok) and mean squared error (MSE); MSE is scaled by 10^{-3} to keep the table compact; the main-paper figure plots the corresponding raw MSE values on log axes. The table highlights the diagnostic role of rate–distortion: the power-of-two variant closely tracks the token-wise variant across token budgets, so the closed-loop differences should be read as differences in policy prediction difficulty and generation pattern, not as reconstruction failures.

Scheme	LIBERO		RoboMimic		MetaWorld		RoboCasa365		SimplerEnv	
	#Tok	MSE _{10⁻³}	#Tok	MSE _{10⁻³}	#Tok	MSE _{10⁻³}	#Tok	MSE _{10⁻³}	#Tok	MSE _{10⁻³}
Bin	224	0.0	224	0.0	128	1.2	384	0.0	56	0.00
FAST	47.5	0.3	50.9	0.4	20.5	67.9	42.2	0.2	11.0	0.19
QueST	16	2.8	16	3.1	16	24.9	16	1.5	4	0.94
ACodec	16	0.7	16	2.3	16	8.2	16	1.4	16	0.04
OAT ₁ ^{sing}	1	14.7	1	12.4	1	731.4	1	16.0	1	0.81
OAT ₂ ^{sing}	2	7.3	2	7.8	2	110.0	2	8.9	2	0.35
OAT ₄ ^{sing}	4	3.8	4	5.3	4	38.1	4	5.2	4	0.21
OAT ₈ ^{sing}	8	2.1	8	3.1	8	32.7	8	2.5	8	0.11
OAT ₁₆ ^{sing}	16	1.0	16	1.9	16	32.1	16	1.3	16	0.05
OAT ₁ ^{pow2}	1	16.2	1	12.9	1	734.6	1	16.2	1	0.82
OAT ₂ ^{pow2}	2	7.4	2	7.8	2	107.1	2	8.9	2	0.35
OAT ₄ ^{pow2}	4	3.6	4	5.3	4	44.4	4	4.9	4	0.20
OAT ₈ ^{pow2}	8	1.9	8	3.0	8	27.7	8	2.4	8	0.11
OAT ₁₆ ^{pow2}	16	0.9	16	1.8	16	26.4	16	1.2	16	0.06

Table 9: Rate–distortion of action tokenizers. #Tok is the number of discrete action tokens used for one action chunk; for FAST, it is the average BPE length. MSE is measured after detokenization in raw action space and scaled by 10^{-3} ; lower is better. Baseline tokenizers are evaluated at their full generated length, while OAT_k^{sing} and OAT_k^{pow2} decode only the first k ordered tokens to show token-wise and power-of-two partial reconstruction.

F Autoregressive Action Generation with Vision-Language Models

Table 10 gives the tabular values behind the vision-language model (VLM) policy success plots with autoregressive (AR) action token generation in Fig. 8. The table compares OAT with per-dimension Bin, Frequency-space Action Sequence Tokenization (FAST), Quantized Skill Transformer (QueST), and ActionCodec (ACodec). For FAST, symbolic token and policy call counts depend on the generated byte-pair encoding (BPE) length. In the table, # Tokens and # Calls denote the token count and sequential policy call count, while Avg. denotes average. The table separates the two VLM backbones so that tokenizer effects are compared within a fixed policy model, then reports success across the four benchmark groups and two benchmark-balanced summaries. The LIBERO column averages the Long, Goal, Object, and Spatial suites, matching the aggregation used in the main-paper figure.

PaliGemma2								
Scheme	# Tokens	# Calls	LIBERO	RoboMimic	RoboCasa365	SimplerEnv	Avg. Success	Avg. Rank
Bin	$H_a D_a$	H_a	14.2	7.0	3.2	20.5	11.2	13.3
FAST	$ T $	$ T $	70.2	62.0	44.4	17.0	48.4	9.5
QueST	H_l	H_l	65.9	64.5	49.6	54.0	58.5	5.9
ACodec	H_l	1	78.7	54.0	51.2	26.5	52.6	6.3
OAT_1^{sing}	1	1	28.2	10.0	24.8	16.0	19.8	13.0
OAT_2^{sing}	2	2	72.5	29.0	44.8	35.5	45.5	9.4
OAT_4^{sing}	4	4	73.4	42.0	48.0	35.5	49.7	8.6
OAT_8^{sing}	8	8	78.0	65.0	58.8	39.0	60.2	4.8
OAT_{16}^{sing}	16	16	79.7	66.0	60.4	48.5	63.7	2.9
OAT_1^{pow2}	1	1	31.4	8.5	28.4	18.0	21.6	12.3
OAT_2^{pow2}	2	2	73.7	24.5	49.2	44.5	48.0	8.0
OAT_4^{pow2}	4	3	76.3	48.0	62.4	49.0	58.9	5.0
OAT_8^{pow2}	8	4	78.2	53.5	62.8	56.5	62.8	3.3
OAT_{16}^{pow2}	16	5	80.8	60.0	60.4	54.0	63.8	3.0

Qwen3VL								
Scheme	# Tokens	# Calls	LIBERO	RoboMimic	RoboCasa365	SimplerEnv	Avg. Success	Avg. Rank
Bin	$H_a D_a$	H_a	0.0	0.5	1.6	1.0	0.8	14.0
FAST	$ T $	$ T $	62.8	27.5	32.8	5.0	32.0	10.6
QueST	H_l	H_l	58.4	49.0	14.8	6.0	32.1	9.5
ACodec	H_l	1	76.5	63.5	45.2	23.5	52.2	4.5
OAT_1^{sing}	1	1	33.0	12.0	27.2	5.5	19.4	11.8
OAT_2^{sing}	2	2	70.9	29.5	48.4	11.0	40.0	8.8
OAT_4^{sing}	4	4	76.4	34.5	55.2	12.0	44.5	6.8
OAT_8^{sing}	8	8	78.5	52.5	57.6	13.5	50.5	4.1
OAT_{16}^{sing}	16	16	82.0	67.0	62.0	16.0	56.8	1.5
OAT_1^{pow2}	1	1	31.1	8.5	32.8	3.5	19.0	12.4
OAT_2^{pow2}	2	2	72.7	20.0	52.4	13.0	39.5	8.3
OAT_4^{pow2}	4	3	78.8	31.0	53.2	15.0	44.5	5.6
OAT_8^{pow2}	8	4	79.3	47.0	55.6	19.0	50.2	3.8
OAT_{16}^{pow2}	16	5	81.8	48.0	57.6	15.0	50.6	3.5

Table 10: Closed-loop VLM AR policy success rates. Rows are grouped by VLM backbone, action token scheme, action token budget, and sequential policy call count. Entries are mean task success rates over 50 rollouts per task. *Avg. Success* gives equal weight to LIBERO, RoboMimic, RoboCasa365, and SimplerEnv; *Avg. Rank* applies the same aggregation across benchmarks to per-benchmark ranks, where lower is better. For baseline tokenizers, # Tokens and # Calls are symbolic because token counts can depend on benchmark action dimensions or generated BPE length; for OAT^{sing} and OAT^{pow2} , they report the evaluated token budget and the number of policy calls required by the generation pattern.